

The Legacy of Mexico's Drug War on Youth Political Attitudes

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Abstract

How does childhood exposure to large-scale criminal violence and militarized law enforcement shape political attitudes and behavior? We examine the case of Mexico's drug war, where a generation has been raised amidst the country's most violent conflict in over a century. Surveying nearly 3,000 urban youth to measure their political and interpersonal trust, we matched respondents to historical data on criminal violence and military confrontations and operations in their childhood municipalities. Disentangling the effects of criminal violence and military interventions, we find that exposure to homicidal violence during childhood erodes interpersonal trust and trust in law enforcement, while military interventions—especially those involving violent confrontations—undermine trust broadly in federal security institutions and generate political backlash against the parties that governed Mexico during the exposure period. These findings have important implications for young democracies affected by high crime and violence and advance our understanding of how criminal wars influence political socialization.

Keywords: Criminal Violence, Militarization, Political Socialization, Trust, Youth Politics.

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Introduction

Over the past two decades, an entire generation of Mexicans has come of age during the country's deadliest wave of violence since the 1910 Revolution. The ongoing "drug war" has claimed more than 450,000 lives and led to over 100,000 disappearances since December 2006.¹ Millions of Mexicans have transitioned to adulthood in communities torn apart by violence and insecurity, witnessing an unprecedented militarization of public security and public life more generally. This generation now constitutes one-third of the country's voting-age population.² Despite the scale and intensity of this conflict, little is known about its sociopolitical impact on the youth. How does growing up in communities marked by large-scale criminal violence and militarized security policies shape young people's political attitudes and behaviors?

This question highlights a significant gap in the literature, as youth make up a disproportionately large share of victims and perpetrators of organized criminal violence (Chioda, 2017; Muggah and Tobón, 2018; Rivera, 2016; Sweeten et al., 2013). Our study addresses this gap by examining how childhood exposure to both criminal violence and militarized law enforcement shapes political trust and attitudes among Mexican youth, albeit in nuanced ways. While existing research has documented the effects of exposure to violence in adulthood, far less is known about how early-life exposure shapes political attitudes and behaviors. Drawing on insights from political socialization theories (Campbell et al., 1980; Green et al., 2008; Healy and Malhotra, 2013; Hyman, 1959) and research on the attitudinal and behavioral effects of exposure to violence (Bateson, 2012; Bauer et al., 2016; Balcells and Torrats-Espinosa, 2018) and militarized security (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021; Masullo and Morisi, 2024), this study demonstrates that early-life exposure to violence and conflict has lasting consequences for political attitudes in adulthood.

A key contribution of our work is showing how different types of exposure shape these attitudes by theoretically distinguishing and empirically testing the distinct effects of lethal criminal violence and

¹Based on official data from the Mexican government. This information is publicly available from the National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI) and the Registro Nacional de Personas Desaparecidas y No Localizadas (RNPДNO).

²As of January 2025, Mexico has over 37 million registered voters aged under 34 years, representing nearly 37% of the national registry. See <https://www.ine.mx/credencial/estadisticas-lista-nominal-padron-electoral/>

military interventions. Specifically, we argue that childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence should negatively affect trust in both the community and law enforcement later in life.³ In contrast, childhood exposure to state-led militarized operations should decrease trust in specific institutions responsible for these operations. In Mexico, the detrimental impact on trust is more likely to be observed in government authorities and state security forces such as the federal police (or national guard) and the military, which were deployed throughout the country to combat organized criminal groups (OCGs). However, we note that although military interventions often coincide with increased violence, this is not always the case. We adjudicate between military-cartel confrontations versus military operations alone to explore conditional effects.

To test our empirical expectations, we use an original in-person survey of nearly 3000 individuals representative of Mexico's urban population aged 16-29. A distinctive feature of our survey design is that respondents indicate where they spent the majority of their childhood, enabling us to match them with fine-grained municipal data on criminal violence and militarized law enforcement during their childhood. Specifically, we construct measures of childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence, armed confrontations between military forces and drug trafficking organizations, and military operations based on respondents' birth year and childhood municipality of residence.

Thus, the core of our empirical strategy exploits variation in exposure to violence and militarized law enforcement during childhood based on respondents' geographic location and date of birth. In essence, we test whether respondents exposed to varying levels of violence, military confrontations, and military operations during childhood exhibit different levels of interpersonal and political trust. To strengthen causal identification, we also implement a quasi-experimental design that treats the 2007 deployment of military forces to combat drug cartels as an exogenous policy shock, building upon previous research that has employed similar approaches (e.g., [Flores-Macías, 2018](#); [Trejo and Skigin, 2024](#)).

The results confirm our expectations: (1) Youths who grew up in the most violent environments exhibit lower levels of trust in law enforcement authorities and their communities; and (2) military confrontations and operations negatively impact trust in the authorities involved in the militarization of

³We focus on trust as our primary dependent variable because trust in institutions and in one's community is vital to understanding democratic functioning and social cooperation ([Citrin and Stoker, 2018](#); [Warren, 2018](#)). Childhood is also a critical period for the formation of beliefs about authority, legitimacy, and social trust ([Erikson, 1963](#); [Koenig and Harris, 2007](#)).

public security—specifically, the federal police, the military, and, to some extent, the government. The results of exposure to military interventions are strongest when they involve violent confrontations. We also find that citizens may not lose trust in the government as a whole but instead hold specific politicians accountable for militarized security policies. Analyzing how violence and militarized law enforcement shaped vote choice in the June 2021 midterm election among voting-aged respondents, we find backlash against the PAN and PRI and higher null voting and abstention, likely in reaction to drug-war-era military actions. Taken together, these findings support the argument that citizens selectively punish politicians linked to militarized security strategies, and that such efforts may foster political disaffection.

Our findings do not discount the fact that exposure to drug war violence during other life stages influences political attitudes. Rather, we show that childhood exposure has a direct effect on political attitudes that is not confounded by alternative explanations or later exposure. This is one of the key contributions of our study. Previous research has examined the effects of organized criminal violence on political participation (Córdova, 2019; Dorff, 2017; Trelles and Carreras, 2012), electoral accountability (Carreras and Visconti, 2022; Ley, 2017), political competition (Daniele and Dipoppa, 2017; Trejo and Ley, 2021), and policy preferences (García-Ponce et al., 2021; Visconti, 2020; Laterzo, 2024), among other political outcomes (García-Ponce, 2025). Newer research has extended this work to consider the impacts of militarized law enforcement on political attitudes (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021; Masullo and Morisi, 2024). However, these studies have focused on adulthood, and the effect of exposure on relatively contemporaneous attitude formation; the political consequences of growing up in communities affected by criminal violence and related conflict have largely been overlooked. We extend this literature by shifting the focus to this critical younger age group.

We also contribute to research on the formation of political beliefs and the causal effects of childhood experiences on political attitudes. Childhood socialization processes and life conditions heavily influence political attitudes, behavior, and preferences in adulthood (Campbell et al., 1980; Green et al., 2008; Healy and Malhotra, 2013; Hyman, 1959; De Neve, 2015; Jennings and Niemi, 2014). Numerous studies show that childhood exposure to violence—particularly during civil war—affects human capital accumulation (Chamarbagwala and Morán, 2011; Justino et al., 2014; Leon, 2012; Shemyakina, 2011), health-related outcomes (Akbulut-Yuksel, 2017; Akresh et al., 2012), and broader human

development. This trauma can even be transmitted across generations (Lupu and Peisakhin, 2017). We advance this scholarship by showing that childhood exposure to criminal violence and militarized security has lasting effects on adult political attitudes and voting preferences.

While our study is focused on Mexico, it offers broader insights for other contexts. Many countries across Latin America and beyond face unprecedented crises of criminal violence, territorial control by non-state armed groups, and increasingly militarized government responses. Understanding how these experiences influence the political attitudes, behaviors, and beliefs of young people coming of age during these conflicts is vital for understanding and addressing threats to democratic governance.

The remainder of the article is structured as follows. We first present our theoretical framework and situate our argument within the relevant literature, then provide historical context on Mexico's drug war and outline our empirical expectations. Next, we describe our data collection and empirical approach. We then report the main findings and discuss their implications. We conclude by underscoring the need for further research on how rising criminal violence shapes the political beliefs and values of younger generations across the Global South.

Theoretical Framework

The notion that early-life exposure to protracted violence can significantly impact the development of political attitudes and behavior finds support in two complementary strands of research. The first underscores the influence of childhood experiences in shaping political beliefs but seldom considers the influence of exposure to crime and violence. The second establishes a link between exposure to violence and subsequent political attitudes and behaviors, but focuses primarily on adults. Our study weaves these literatures together to reveal the impacts of childhood exposure to criminal violence and military interventions on political attitudes within the context of Mexico's drug war.

Childhood Experiences and Political Socialization

Cornerstone research in developmental psychology and neuroscience shows that the architecture of the human brain is affected by early childhood experiences and environmental factors, particularly during the first eight to ten years of life. Early life experiences—positive and negative—provide the foundation

for future behavioral, cognitive, and social skill development (Feldman, 2020; Heim and Nemeroff, 2001; Knudsen et al., 2006). Adverse or traumatic experiences— especially in this formative period —have strong impacts on outcomes such as skill development and later employability (Shonkoff and Phillips, 2000), mental health (Boullier and Blair, 2018), high-risk behaviors (Campbell et al., 2016), and personality traits (Fletcher and Schurer, 2017).

Childhood experiences heavily influence the formation of political attitudes, behaviors, and beliefs. Building on Hyman (1959)’s seminal work on the political socialization of children in the United States, longitudinal and inter-generational studies have consistently found persistent relationships between processes of childhood socialization and political beliefs (Hatemi et al., 2009; Jennings and Niemi, 2014). Indeed, political identities adopted early in life strongly predict adult political views (Campbell et al., 1980; Green et al., 2008; Healy and Malhotra, 2013), and powerful early-life experiences can shape ideology and policy preferences. For instance, Madestam and Yanagizawa-Drott (2012) find that childhood exposure to patriotic events in the U.S. increases Republican identification, votes for Republicans, and turnout later in life, while Guo et al. (2023) show that early-life famine severity experienced by Chinese politicians influences their policy preferences.

A growing body of work corroborates that social cognition in early childhood is already oriented toward group living, setting the foundation of political sensitivities and attitudes (Reifen-Tagar and Cimpian, 2022; Wegemer and Vandell, 2020). This challenges the assumption that young children lack the cognitive capacity and social understanding to develop political thought (Rizzo et al., 2020; Guidetti et al., 2021; Taylor, 2020). Most of these studies have primarily focused on understanding the development of political beliefs in the context of the U.S. and Western Europe. In Mexico, the foundational work by Segovia (1975) demonstrated that Mexican children’s political attitudes in the early 1970s mirrored the authoritarian tendencies of the hegemonic one-party regime.⁴

Although we know that childhood plays a foundational role in shaping attitudes and behaviors, existing research often overlooks the significance of childhood exposure to violence on political atti-

⁴The context of Segovia’s research differs from that of contemporary Mexico. Whereas Segovia studied the deliberately orchestrated political socialization of an authoritarian regime, we examine the post-democratic transition era. Still, Segovia’s core insight—that institutional and environmental experiences during childhood fundamentally shape political orientations—offers an important historical antecedent for our analysis.

tudes. Only a handful of studies have paid attention to this subject. [Lupu and Peisakhin \(2017\)](#) provide evidence of inter-generational effects of violence on ethnic identity and political attitudes among Crimean Tatars who suffered the violence of deportation. Similar patterns have been shown in South Korea ([Hong and Kang, 2017](#)) and in Africa ([Adhvaryu and Fenske, 2023](#)). This nascent literature—in tandem with well-established knowledge of the larger impact of childhood events on adult attitudes and behaviors—provides strong suggestive evidence that exposure to violence, as well as to state interventions aimed at curbing it, should shape political orientations later in life. Importantly, the effects may vary with the type of violence, since different forms of violence are not equally visible, salient, or psychologically processed. Our study contributes to this literature by examining how exposure to organized criminal violence and drug-war militarized operations during childhood in Mexico affects political attitudes in adulthood.

Exposure to Violence, Military Interventions, and Political Attitudes

A large body of research finds that exposure to violence increases political engagement (e.g., [Bauer et al., 2016](#); [Bateson, 2012](#)). However, studies that isolate different types of violence exposure present more nuanced findings ([García-Ponce, 2019](#); [Grossman et al., 2015](#); [Jones et al., 2017](#)). In Latin America, where organized crime is a major security threat, exposure to criminal violence seems to negatively impact political trust, particularly in security-related institutions ([Malone, 2010](#); [Blanco, 2013](#); [Blanco and Ruiz, 2013](#); [Corbacho et al., 2015](#); [Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017](#)). This suggests that individuals attribute insecurity to the actors that generate it—or fail to prevent it—a pattern observed beyond the region as well ([Deglow and Sundberg, 2021](#)). Although these studies do not connect childhood experiences to adult behaviors or attitudes, they show that experiences across one’s lifecycle are impactful. This does not contradict evidence that crime and violence can also increase political participation or prosocial behavior; victimization can simultaneously reduce trust, and increase participation in social and political organizations ([Pazzona, 2020](#)).

Effects on institutional trust are context-specific. In countries with lackluster justice systems, personal experience with crime erodes support only for the police. But the negative impacts of violence on institutional trust can travel beyond the criminal justice system ([Malone, 2010](#)). Some find that exposure to crime and insecurity decreases trust in government entities more generally. In Mexico, criminal

violence demobilizes voters (Ley, 2018) and support for the national incumbent party varies inversely with prevailing levels of violence (Ley, 2017). In poor-performing, high-crime countries, fear of neighborhood crime has a negative relationship with measures of diffuse support (Blanco and Ruiz, 2013; Malone, 2010). Such studies show that crime exposure can transcend measures of specific support, affecting individuals' trust in major national institutions and the entire regime.

Violence exposure can also negatively affect interpersonal relationships and social cohesion. In terms of psychological effects, this includes a decreased ability to express empathy, increased antisocial behavior, and the normalization of aggression (Hawkins et al., 2000; Guerra et al., 2003; Baskin and Sommers, 2015). In addition to direct cognitive and behavioral effects, exposure to violence leads to related secondary effects by increasing the likelihood that individuals interact with the justice system (Hawkins et al., 2000; Siegel et al., 2019). Crime victimization during adulthood has also been shown to decrease overall horizontal trust in one's community, family, and friends (Salmi et al., 2007; Corbacho et al., 2015).

While deployment of law enforcement to combat drug-related violence typically entails exacerbated conflict—including substantial civilian casualties and human rights abuses (Calderón et al., 2015; Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2023)—effects of this exposure may be nuanced. Research indicates that conflict related to law enforcement operations should have similar negative effects on attitudes. In Mexico, support for militarization decreases if operations cause civilian casualties, but not when victimization is isolated to cartel members (Masullo and Morisi, 2024). Given that such operations often lead to increased violence, negative attitudes are likely to grow following exposure to law enforcement-related conflict.

However, not all military operations necessarily entail violence, and operations without conflict may not have these effects. Indeed, individuals tend to be supportive of military operations and war in response to an imminent threat, but civilian costs can curtail this support (Dill and Schubiger, 2021). Further, in the context of Mexico, Flores-Macías and Zarkin (2021) show that military uniforms and weapons are perceived positively. Little research has adjudicated if exposure to military presence itself, versus presence involving violence and conflict, has differing effects on trust.

Hence, prior work suggests that childhood exposure to violence, insecurity, and militarized law enforcement can diminish trust in various entities, both at the government and community levels. How-

ever, it also suggests that exposure should have differential effects on trust depending on the type of insecurity at hand. Exposure to criminal violence should have more general impacts on trust in one's community but also law enforcement agencies, who may be seen as responsible for preventing and responding to these acts. On the other hand, violence and insecurity more directly attributed to the state—such as conflicts between law enforcement and criminal groups—should affect trust in a distinct manner. This insecurity may be seen more attributable to specific actors deployed (e.g., the military, police) and officials involved in this deployment. Law enforcement deployments on their own, without necessarily entailing violence, should not necessarily have negative effects.

A Generation Exposed to Mexico's Drug War

In December 2006, former Mexican president Felipe Calderón began a war against organized crime by deploying military forces throughout Northern and Western Mexico. Drug cartels in the country had flourished during the years prior, particularly during the era of one-party rule. Trejo and Ley (2018), for example, show that in the 1990s, cartels engaged in significant violence, especially during periods of gubernatorial power shift. When one-party rule was broken, cartels continued their violent practices in attempts to re-establish and hold onto their power (Osorio, 2013; Ríos, 2015; Trejo and Ley, 2020).

The beginning of Calderón's administration marked a significant public security policy shift. The drug war became the centerpiece of his presidency (Lessing, 2017), and the Mexican army (under the direction of the Secretariat of National Defense, SEDENA), which had not been trained to fight OCGs, became the leading force behind its operations. Federal police were often deployed in tandem with these forces, while lower level police forces were often reported to be in collaboration with drug trafficking groups.⁵

In this way, the country largely saw the constabularization of the military, where the armed forces assumed domestic public safety tasks. Militarized policing was also present, where civilian-led police forces were equipped with military-grade weapons, gear, and engaged in military-style tactics, often in tandem with military forces (Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021). This entailed the adoption of security strategies developed for war, leading to human rights violations and the deterioration of democratic

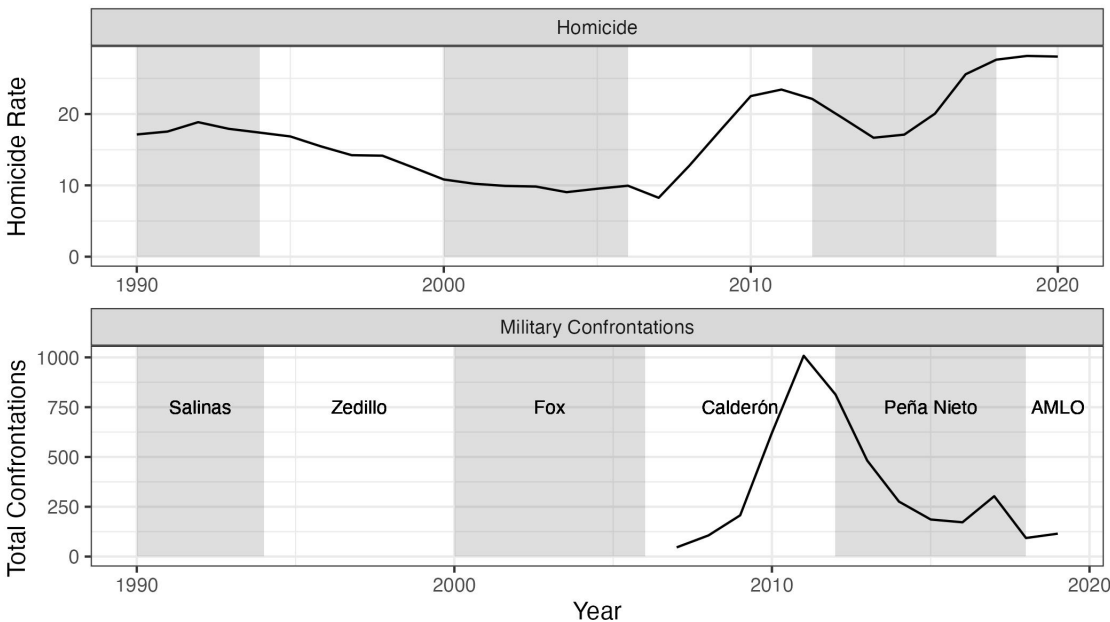
⁵<https://www.nbcnews.com/id/wbna8206233>, last accessed on June 27, 2023

controls (Brewer and Verduzco, 2022; Magaloni and Rodriguez, 2020).

During the subsequent presidential administration, President Enrique Peña Nieto (2012-2018) adopted a similar strategy towards organized crime. In addition to the domestic deployment of the military, he created a new national police force (the national gendarmerie) to assist in the efforts (Council on Foreign Relations, 2022). Although the number of military operations declined, the core of his security strategy relied on capturing or killing criminal bosses, seizing drugs, and eradicating illicit crops. This approach deepened under President Andrés Manuel López Obrador (2018-2024), although he applied different rhetoric to combating crime (Deare, 2021).

The militarization of public security has failed to reduce crime and violence in Mexico. As shown in Figure 1 (upper panel), despite a modest decline in the homicide rate at the beginning of Peña Nieto’s administration, homicides began to trend up again in 2015 and remained at record-high levels during López Obrador’s administration. Approximately 420,000 people have been killed and around 120,000 have been reported disappeared since the start of the drug war.

Figure 1: Homicide Rate and Military Confrontations, 1990–2020



Note: Annual homicide rate and military confrontations across presidential administrations in Mexico (1990–2020), based on data from INEGI and SEDENA, respectively.

The production of violence involves a complex network of armed actors, including OCGs, state security forces, and vigilante groups, making it difficult to precisely estimate how many homicides are

directly attributable to the drug war. However, there is growing evidence that the law-enforcement approach adopted over the past two decades has contributed to the escalation of violence (Calderón et al., 2015; Dell, 2015; Phillips, 2015). Although the Mexican state deployed troops domestically in the postrevolutionary era to suppress political opposition (Rath, 2013), the military's role in everyday public security was far less visible and consequential prior to the drug war's militarized turn. Work by Flores-Macías (2018) suggests that militarized anti-drug enforcement has weakened the Mexican state's capacity not only to provide public order, but also to extract fiscal resources.

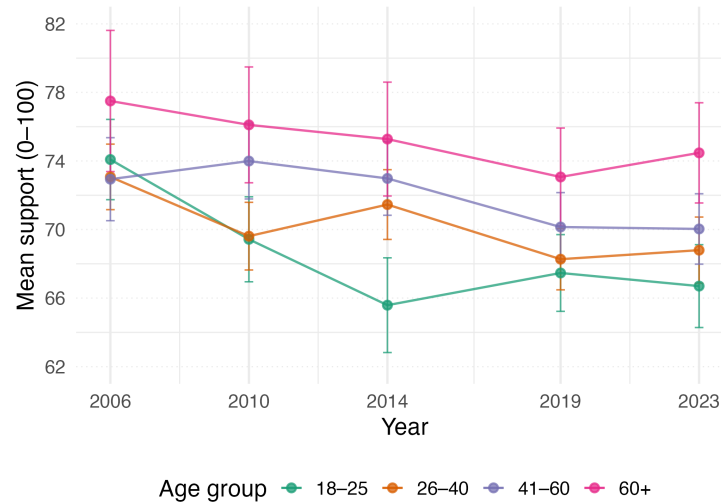
Thus, the drug war initiated by Calderón represents a defining era in Mexico's modern history. An entire generation of Mexicans was born, raised, and transitioned to adulthood during the most violent episode in the history of the country over the past century. Those who were school-age children in the early years of the drug war now comprise a substantial part of the voting-age population. Many of these young adults grew up in communities with unprecedentedly high levels of crime and violence, witnessing both the consolidation of the militarization of public security and the government's failures to make their communities safer.

In addition, youths account for an overwhelmingly high percentage of victims of criminal violence in Mexico. Based on official statistics from the National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI), the homicide rate among youths aged 15–24 increased by three-fold between 2007 and 2011. As of 2021, the year of our survey, approximately 21% of the victims of intentional homicide were 24 years old or younger—more than half were under 34 years old. As a result of this, life expectancy has deteriorated among males and it has stagnated among females (Aburto et al., 2016; Canudas-Romo et al., 2017).

The effects of criminal violence on young people's life choices and political beliefs remain understudied in Mexico and beyond. Looking at the impact on youths is important for developing policies that foster social and political stability, democratic norms, and social cohesion among the younger generation. As shown in Figure 2, data from the AmericasBarometer (LAPOP Lab, 2024) indicates a significant decline in democratic support among the youngest citizens. This disparity is also evident in voter turnout rates among younger and older citizens. For example, during the 2021 midterm elections, held just a few weeks prior to our survey, only 41% of eligible voters aged 20–29 cast ballots. In contrast, turnout among voters aged 50–80 exceeded 60%.⁶

⁶See Census Counts of Citizen Participation 2009–2021 from the National Electoral Institute

Figure 2: Trends in Support for Democracy in Mexico across Age Groups, 2006–2023



Note: Support for democracy measured on a 0–100 scale using survey-weighted means from five AmericasBarometer waves in Mexico. Vertical bars indicate 95% confidence intervals. (LAPOP Lab, 2024).

This generational disaffection with democracy is not unique to Mexico. Across Latin America, younger citizens generally express lower trust in institutions and weaker commitment to democracy than older generations (Latinobarómetro Study, 2023; UNDP, 2024). Nonetheless, Mexico represents an extreme case in terms of the violence and insecurity accompanying its democratic era. The intensity of the drug war provides a critical test of the impact of violence on youth attitudes. By focusing on violence in Mexico’s context, we isolate a factor that is plausibly a key driver of youth disaffection.

Empirical Expectations

Individuals raised in communities marked by pervasive violent crime and impunity are likely to develop mistrust toward government, security institutions, and even their own communities. Drawing on research on political socialization, evidence on the political consequences of violence, and accounts of Mexico’s militarized drug war, we hypothesize that childhood exposure to drug-war violence leaves a distinct imprint on political attitudes. However, we argue that not all forms of exposure exert the same influence. We distinguish between three forms of exposure: *lethal criminal violence*, *military presence*, and violent *military confrontations*. Each varies in visibility and in the extent to which responsibility

<https://ine.mx/transparencia/datos-abiertos/visualizacion-datos/conteos-censales-participacion/>

can be attributed to state actors, and we therefore expect these forms of exposure to differentially shape the political trust of Mexican youth.

A growing literature emphasizes that the political consequences of violence depend not only on its intensity but also on its visibility and attribution. As [Durán-Martínez \(2015\)](#) notes, criminal organizations often deploy clandestine or concealed violence to regulate illicit markets while minimizing the risk of detection and prosecution. At other times, violence is made deliberately visible and spectacular, executed to challenge state authority, intimidate the public, or signal dominance. Violence also varies in the extent to which responsibility can be clearly assigned—some events are easily attributable to the (in)action of specific actors, while others remain ambiguous. These dimensions shape attitude formation: visible and clearly attributable violence should facilitate more precise belief updating than diffuse or ambiguous events. We use these conceptual distinctions to derive empirical expectations for each of our three exposure measures.

First, *lethal criminal violence* signals severe insecurity, constitutes the most publicly documented manifestation of drug-war violence—captured most directly through homicide statistics—and reflects a profound failure of public security. Yet despite its severity, such violence often involves unknown perpetrators, contested victim status, and considerable ambiguity regarding responsibility. As a result, exposure to homicidal violence is likely to generate generalized fear and uncertainty rather than precise attribution. We therefore expect childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence to have its strongest corrosive effects on social cohesion and on trust in public security institutions. Specifically, we hypothesize that higher levels of exposure to homicidal violence during childhood will erode *interpersonal trust*, as persistent insecurity encourages withdrawal from community life. We also anticipate declines in trust in the *federal police*. Given the federal government’s mandate to combat organized crime, responsibility attribution is clearer at the federal level than for subnational police forces.⁷ The distinction between federal and subnational policing offers a strong test of our responsibility attribution mechanism.

Second, we argue that exposure to the state’s militarized response to the drug war has distinct implications for political trust, depending on whether that exposure involves violence. We first consider violent *military confrontations*, i.e., direct armed clashes between military or militarized federal forces

⁷Citizens struggle to assign responsibility for public security, especially where mandates overlap and authority is fragmented ([León, 2011](#); [Carlin et al., 2015](#)). In Mexico, this ambiguity is pronounced for subnational police forces.

and criminal organizations. These events are highly visible, explicitly violent, and readily attributable to state security policy. Rather than signaling protection or order, repeated exposure to such confrontations during childhood may communicate that militarization fails to deliver lasting security and instead brings sustained conflict into civilian spaces. We therefore hypothesize that childhood exposure to violent military confrontations will have particularly strong negative effects on trust in the institutions responsible for the design and implementation of this strategy: the *military*, the *federal government*, and the *federal police*.

In contrast, the mere presence of *military operations*—the deployment of troops without direct confrontation or visible acts of violence—may have more muted effects. While military presence can reshape daily life as the state attempts to maintain or restore order, it does not necessarily involve overt violence or civilian harm. Given the historically high levels of public confidence in the Mexican military, which have proven resilient even during the drug war (Bailey et al., 2013; Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2021), we expect that exposure to military presence alone will not generate the same erosion of institutional trust observed in contexts marked by violent confrontations. Distinguishing between violent and non-violent forms of militarization allows us to assess whether declines in trust are driven by the presence of security forces per se or by their engagement in visible and violent conflict.

Together, these expectations allow us to isolate the distinct effects of different types of exposure and test mechanisms through which violence affects trust. By contrasting ambiguous criminal violence with violence involving state security forces, and by distinguishing violent from non-violent forms of military involvement, we provide a framework for understanding how early exposure to violence shapes trust in communities and political institutions later in life.

Empirical Approach

Survey and Data

Our goal is to examine how childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence and drug war military interventions shapes individuals' trust in political institutions and their communities later in life. To investigate this, we leverage three primary data sources: (1) an original survey fielded in Mexico among youths; (2) official municipal-level data on homicide rates over the past few decades; and (3) official

records detailing the frequency of military confrontations and operations in each municipality.⁸

In partnership with Buendia & Marquez, a leading survey firm based in Mexico City, and a team of local enumerators, we conducted an in-person survey of 2,880 young individuals aged 16 to 29 in June 2021. The sample is representative of urban Mexico for our target age group. Ethical considerations were a central concern in the design of our survey. All participation was informed, voluntary, and confidential. Since our study did not include people under 16 years of age, parental consent was not required. The research presented no more than minimal risk to subjects, researchers, and enumerators, with the only potential concern being possible discomfort when responding to certain questions. Participants were informed of this risk and the consent process emphasized their right to withdraw from the study at any time. See Appendix 1 for a description of our participant recruitment process and our adherence to principles of ethical human subjects research.

We focus on urban Mexico for two reasons. First, the forms of violence experienced in urban versus rural areas of Mexico are different in nature. Rural areas are more likely to experience violence associated with illicit crop production, land disputes, or the extortion of agricultural workers in a context of limited state presence (Dube et al., 2016; Herrera and Martinez-Alvarez, 2022), which is why the socio-demographic profiles of victims and perpetrators tend to be different than in urban areas (Villarreal, 2004; Muñoz-Sánchez et al., 2022). Second, 80% of Mexico's population resides in urban areas. A similar percentage of homicides and violent crime take place in metropolitan areas, where youths are at a disproportionately high risk of becoming targets of organized criminal violence. Therefore, while rural violence is prevalent in many communities of Mexico, we believe it is conceptually distinct.

Our survey was representative of common sociodemographic characteristics, such as income and education level. In addition, we employed a unique strategy to ensure representativity of the various levels of municipal violence across the country. Within this strategy, we considered three variables that capture variations in violence at this geographic level: homicide rates, reported non-homicidal crime, and perceived levels of violence. Although homicide rates are often used as a benchmark for the prevalence of violence, we chose to involve additional measures as homicide does not capture the complete reality of citizen insecurity.

These measures are typically not available at the subnational level, particularly at units as small as

⁸See García-Ponce and Laterzo-Tingley (2026) for all data and replication materials.

the municipality. To circumvent this issue, we rely upon measures available at the national and city level from Mexico's National Survey of Urban Public Security (ENSU) and use multilevel regression and poststratification (MrP) to generate subnational measures (Gelman and Little, 1997). We model respondents' perceptions of violence and reported victimization as a function of selected sociodemographic characteristics (i.e., location, age, gender, occupation, education) and generate municipal-level estimates with such models via poststratification using Mexico's 2015 intercensus. We thus create 157 municipal estimates of both reported victimization and perceived insecurity. We utilize these estimates and the most recently reported homicide rates collected by the Executive Secretariat of the National System of Public Security (SESNSP) to stratify our survey sample.⁹ We limit our sampling frame to municipalities surveyed by ENSU, and order these units based on the three levels of insecurity via seriation.

Our outcome variables were measured by asking respondents to rate their level of trust on a 1–7 scale, with 1 indicating no trust and 7 indicating a great deal of trust. Respondents completed this exercise for the following groups: their community (neighbors), the police (municipal, state, federal), the military (army and navy), and the government (federal, state, local).¹⁰ We standardize these variables and center them at 0, allowing us to interpret results in terms of standard deviations from the mean.

To measure exposure to lethal criminal violence and the military strategy of the drug war, we match respondents with administrative data regarding these factors at the municipal level. To do so, respondents were asked where they were born (either the municipality where they currently reside, or elsewhere). This is uncommon in current public opinion surveys in the area and allows us to measure exposure to violence and militarization in one's childhood hometown.¹¹ We then rely on these munic-

⁹We rely on two sources of homicide data due to differences in temporal coverage and availability. INEGI offers the most reliable and comprehensive historical data on homicide counts, and it serves as our primary source for estimating long-term homicide rates. However, at the time we fielded our survey, SESNSP was the only source providing municipal-level homicide data for 2020, which we used for stratifying our sample.

¹⁰The federal police in Mexico was replaced by the national guard in 2020. In light of this change happening 18 months before our survey, respondents were asked about their opinions regarding the federal police *or* national guard, in case they were not yet familiar with the change.

¹¹We drop respondents that grew up in a different municipality than their current residence, as their exposure cannot be confidently measured. This leaves us with 2,425 respondents. Appendix 10 demonstrates that our outcome variables are uncorrelated with one's move during childhood.

ipal identifiers to calculate their exposure to both violence and militarization.

First, to measure childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence, we draw on annual municipal homicide counts from Mexico's National Institute of Statistics and Geography (INEGI) and population estimates from the National Population Council (CONAPO). For each respondent, we calculate the average homicide rate experienced during the first ten years of life, based on their birth year and the municipality where they spent the majority of their childhood. Intentional homicides constitute the most complete and reliable proxy for lethal criminal violence over our study period, as death certificates are processed through medical and forensic systems and coded by both medical personnel and the Attorney General's Office.¹² Furthermore, most of the dramatic increases in homicidal violence during the drug-war period stem from inter- and intra-OCG conflict (Calderón et al., 2015).¹³

Second, to capture exposure to drug war military interventions, we calculate the average level of exposure to military confrontations and operations across individuals' first ten years of life. Data for these measures were collected via right-to-information requests filed to the Mexican government by Flores-Macías and Zarkin (2021, 2023).¹⁴ To capture *military confrontations* we utilize municipal-level data regarding the military's confrontations with criminal groups (*enfrentamientos*). This is a count variable, indicating the number of confrontations each year between SEDENA and suspected criminals across all municipalities.¹⁵ To measure *military presence*, we draw on data regarding operations, which

¹²Our measure requires data beginning in 1992, the birth year of the oldest respondents in our survey. No other municipal-level indicator of lethal criminal violence is available consistently for this time range. For instance, the Criminal Violence in Mexico Database (Trejo and Ley, 2020), one of the most comprehensive alternatives, spans 1994–2012.

¹³Other forms of violence—extortion, kidnapping, and especially disappearances—are inconsistently recorded. Visible lethal violence also serves as a salient signal of OCG presence and state weakness (Durán-Martínez, 2015), and increases in homicides typically accompany broader intensifications of organized criminal activity. A limitation is that disappearances are not classified as homicides unless a body is recovered, and official data on disappearances are incomplete and inconsistent, particularly in earlier years. If disappearances shape political attitudes through mechanisms distinct from visible violence, our measure may not fully capture those effects. However, in Appendix 3 we show a strong correlation between municipal-level disappearances and homicide rates.

¹⁴These data were collected by Flores-Macías & Zarkin via right-to-information requests filed to the Mexican government (the National Institution for Transparency, Access to Information, and Personal Data Protection, INAI) and published in Flores-Macías and Zarkin (2023). Information requests #0000700018420 and #000070023818.

¹⁵While individuals were also exposed to deployments of federal police, data regarding this is not

Table 1: Descriptive Statistics of Key Variables

	Min.	Median	Mean	Max.	SD
Trust:					
Federal Police	1.00	5.00	4.81	7.00	1.68
Subnational Police	1.00	3.50	3.59	7.00	1.52
Federal Government	1.00	4.00	4.24	7.00	1.70
Subnational Governmentt	1.00	4.00	3.76	7.00	1.52
Military	1.00	5.50	5.32	7.00	1.46
Neighbors	1.00	4.00	4.25	7.00	1.87
Exposure (10 yrs):					
Avg Lethal Crim. Violence Exposure (10 yrs)	0.64	10.41	13.63	92.67	12.12
Avg Military Conflict Exposure (10 yrs)	0.00	0.00	0.33	7.80	0.95
Avg Military Operations Exposure (10 yrs)	0.00	0.00	0.11	0.80	0.20
Sociodemographics:					
Gender (Female = 1)	0.00	0.00	0.47	1.00	0.50
SES Scale	0.00	1.98	1.96	2.56	0.54
Education	1.00	7.00	6.69	10.00	1.92
Age	16.00	21.00	21.72	29.00	4.18

Note: Sample size is 2,425 respondents. Individuals who spent their childhood in a municipality different from their current place of residence are excluded.

indicates if the military (specifically the army, or SEDENA) was deployed to a municipality to participate in law enforcement operations. Functions included patrols, checkpoints, and detentions. This is a binary variable, indicating if at least one of these functions was present or not.

These two measures of militarization are complementary and allow for a nuanced assessment of military strategy and policing at the municipal level. Confrontations, our first measure, allow us to explore if drug war-interventions that explicitly involved violence and conflict has long-term effects on attitudes. Operations (our second measure) allow us to explore whether or not exposure to deployment—without necessitating violent conflict—has such effects.

Our survey also collected sociodemographic information which we use as controls. These variables are respondent gender, level of education, and socioeconomic status (SES). To create our SES index, we rely on a battery of questions regarding individuals' possession of a series of assets and use principal component analysis (PCA) to create a singular variable (Appendix 4). Descriptive statistics are

available. The measures we utilize are a suitable proxy for military and federal police deployment, as presidents often deployed the military along with federal police to confront OCGs (Felbab-Brown, 2014).

presented in Table 1.

Methods

We employ two complementary identification strategies to test if childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence, military confrontations, or military operations affects trust later in life. The first exploits variation in childhood exposure to our independent variables based on year of birth and geographic location. The second strategy leverages the sudden, large-scale troop deployments that began in 2007 as a quasi-experimental shock, enabling us to isolate the causal effects of exposure to both military confrontations and operations.

Exposure Defined by Birth Year & Childhood Municipality

Following recent work on the long-run consequences of early-life violence (e.g., [Gutiérrez-Romero, 2024](#); [Justino et al., 2014](#); [Leon, 2012](#)), we exploit exogenous differences in childhood exposure to lethal criminal violence, military confrontations, and military operations that arise from respondents' year of birth and geographic location during their first ten years of life. The resulting variation allows us to compare individuals who, during their formative years, experienced higher or lower levels of criminal violence and military interventions, even though they share either a common birthplace or a common birth year.

Formally, we estimate the following reduced-form specification via OLS:

$$y_{ijt} = \beta_1 V_{jt} + \mathbf{X}_i' \beta_2 + \alpha_j + \phi_t + \varepsilon_{ijt}, \quad (1)$$

where y_{ijt} denotes the trust outcome for individual i born in year t in municipality j . Our parameter of interest, β_1 , captures the effect of childhood violence exposure, measured by

$$V_{jt} = \frac{1}{11} \sum_{a=0}^{10} \text{Violence}_{j,t+a}$$

the average annual intensity of (1) lethal criminal violence, (2) military confrontations, or (3) military operations in municipality j from the respondent's birth year t through age 10. The vector $\mathbf{X}_i$ includes individual covariates—gender, socioeconomic status, and education level—that might corre-

late with both exposure and trust. Municipality fixed effects (α_j) absorb all time-invariant local characteristics, while birth-year fixed effects (ϕ_t) purge nationwide shocks common to each cohort. Identification therefore hinges on within-municipality, across-cohort deviations in violence intensity and on cross-municipality differences experienced by the same cohort. Robust standard errors account for any remaining correlation in unobserved shocks, ε_{ijt} .

Quasi-Experimental Design based on Military Interventions

The nature of the dramatic shock of military deployments across the country in 2007 allows us to leverage a quasi-experimental design for both exposure to confrontations and operations. This strategy is in line with previous research leveraging this shock (Brown et al., 2019; Flores-Macías, 2018; Flores-Macías and Zarkin, 2023; Trejo and Skigin, 2024), and supplements our previous analysis. We can only do so for military-related variables as deployment of the military in drug war operations was rare prior to 2007, while lethal criminal violence was present in the country across all years.¹⁶ Our empirical strategy compares individuals born in the same municipality but in different periods, and individuals born in the same period but in different municipalities, during the drug war’s early years. This design allows us to calculate a debiased estimator which accounts for confounding factors both at the municipal and cohort levels. By comparing across these groups, we incorporate not only a group exposed to the treatment alongside potential confounders, but also a group exposed to those confounders in the absence of the treatment.

To employ this strategy, we define treated individuals and a range of treatment years. As municipalities have gone in and out of treatment over time (varying levels of military presence), and respondents have continuously aged throughout this period, we approach this by conservatively defining a range of years in which the military was domestically active in addition to a cohort of individuals who were consistently younger than 10 years old during this time period. Based on our data, this approach results in examining the years 2007-2011. This period not only represents the height of the drug war’s military interventions but perfectly intersects with a group of respondents under the age of 10 which we can

¹⁶In communication with the federal government provided in information request #0000700233818, transparency officials noted that “between January 1st and December 31st, 2006 there was no personal aggressions against military personnel recorded [domestically].” Rather, confrontations began in 2007. See Appendix 10 for further evidence.

explore utilizing our data—those born between 2001 and 2005. Defining treatment in this way is the most conservative approach. In Table 2 we show that exposure to both military confrontations and operations is balanced across those who were both eligible (born 2001-2005) and ineligible for treatment. Further, in Appendix 15, we also less conservatively define the cohort eligible to be treated.

Table 2: Balance in Exposure to Military Interventions Across Cohorts

	Mean Confrontations	Mean Operations
Cohort: Eligible	1.33	0.35
Cohort: Ineligible	1.39	0.36

Note: Calculated as the average level of confrontations or operations (binary variable) for each group. Those eligible for treatment are those born between 2001 and 2005 in our sample.

With this in mind, we utilize standard OLS models with the following equation:

$$y_{ij} = \beta_1 M_{j[i]} + \beta_2 D_i + \beta_3 M_{j[i]} D_i + \mathbf{X}_i' \boldsymbol{\beta}_4 + \alpha_j + \epsilon_i \quad (2)$$

Here, y_{ij} is the outcome variable observed for respondent i in municipality j . $M_{j[i]}$ represents either the average military confrontations or operations between 2007 and 2011 for each municipality j of residence, for each respondent i . D_i is a binary indicator which is 1 if respondent i was born between 2001 and 2005, and 0 otherwise. The parameter of interest is β_3 , which captures the effect of the interaction between $M_{j[i]}$ and D_i . In the $\mathbf{X}_i$ vector of controls, we also include the age of the respondents to account for the differing effects within each cohort (eligible or ineligible for exposure). We retain municipality-level fixed effects (α_j) as in Equation 1, but we do not include birth-year fixed effects in this model as we include terms for both cohort and age (continuously operationalized).

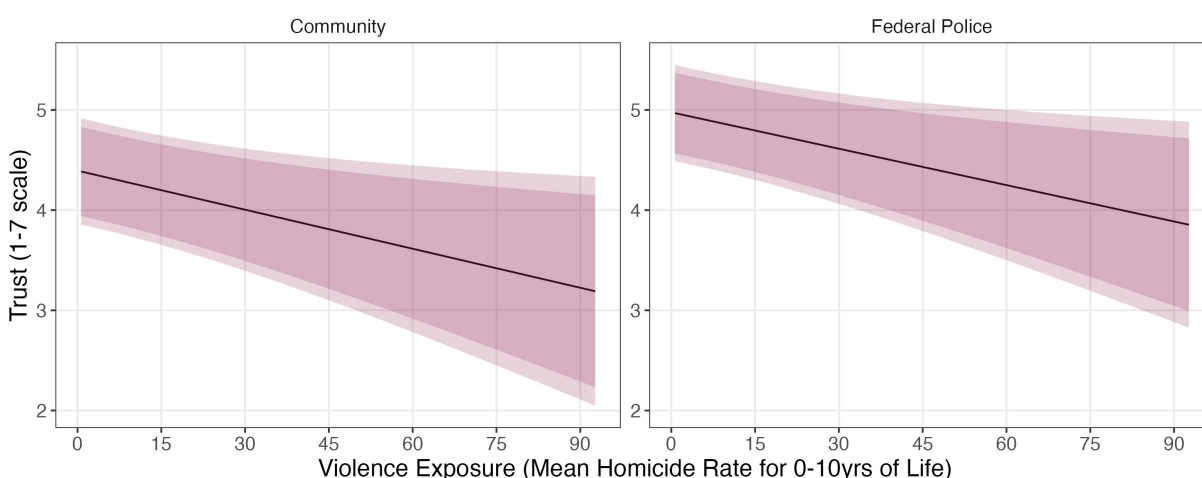
Results

Exposure to Lethal Criminal Violence

Increased exposure to lethal criminal violence during early childhood results in a statistically significant decline in trust in the federal police and one's community later in life (Figure 3). Negative relationships are present for all actors explored, although others are not significant (Table 3). The magnitude of statistically significant results is also notable. To contextualize our findings, consider two individ-

uals: one who spent their first ten years of life in a municipality with an average homicide rate of 40 per 100,000 residents—approximately two standard deviations above the mean—and another who experienced minimal homicidal violence (fewer than one per 100,000). According to our estimates, the former would express 10% less trust in the federal police compared to the latter. These results support our expectations that exposure to criminal violence early in life should not only erode trust in law enforcement, but also one’s community more broadly. In Appendix 9, we demonstrate that this result is driven by the socioeconomically well-off, which comports with literature showing that the rich are especially sensitive to crime shocks (Rueda and Stegmueller, 2016; Clément and Piaser, 2021).

Figure 3: Exposure to Homicide and Decreased Trust



Note: Predicted values from OLS models. corresponding to models 4 and 6 in Table 3. Models used to generate predictions do not use standardized DVs or IVs. Shaded regions represent 90% (dark) and 95% (light) CIs.

Table 3: Exposure to Homicide and Trust

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	−0.039 (0.041)	−0.041 (0.040)	−0.046 (0.038)	−0.087** (0.040)	−0.024 (0.046)	−0.084** (0.037)
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.085	0.090	0.083	0.096

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Exposure to Military Interventions

Results in Tables 4 and 5 report observational estimates of the effect of exposure to military confrontations and operations on trust (Equation 1). Results show that as childhood exposure to military confrontations and operations increases, trust in the federal police and military later in life decreases. Negative relationships with all other variables explored are also present, although only trust in the federal government reaches a traditional level of significance in the case of confrontations (Table 4, $p < 0.1$). The stronger effects restricted to the federal police and military support our theory, suggesting a pattern of actor-specific blame attribution. Results in Appendix 9 demonstrate that the negative relationship between exposure to confrontations and trust is driven by those from lower socioeconomic strata and with lower levels of educational attainment. This is supported by research showing that marginalized groups – particularly youths – are most vulnerable to state-criminal conflict, both in terms of their increased exposure to repressive state security practices (Ryngelblum and Peres, 2021) and their higher likelihood of OCG recruitment and victimization (Juárez et al., 2022).

Results in Tables 6 and 7 correspond to our quasi-experimental assessment, leveraging the exogenous shock of military deployments beginning in late 2006/early 2007 (Equation 2). This strategy is a more stringent and conservative estimation of this effect, utilizing our debiased estimator. Estimates indicate that exposure to military confrontations during one’s formative years is associated with marked declines in trust in the federal government, federal police, and military. Exposure to military operations—which does not necessarily entail conflict—results in consistent negative effects, but are only statistically significant for federal police.¹⁷ In Appendix 12, we provide additional support for this point, isolating the impact of confrontations holding constant exposure to operations. We demonstrate that exposure to violent confrontations have an additional impact on trust, particularly in the federal police and military.

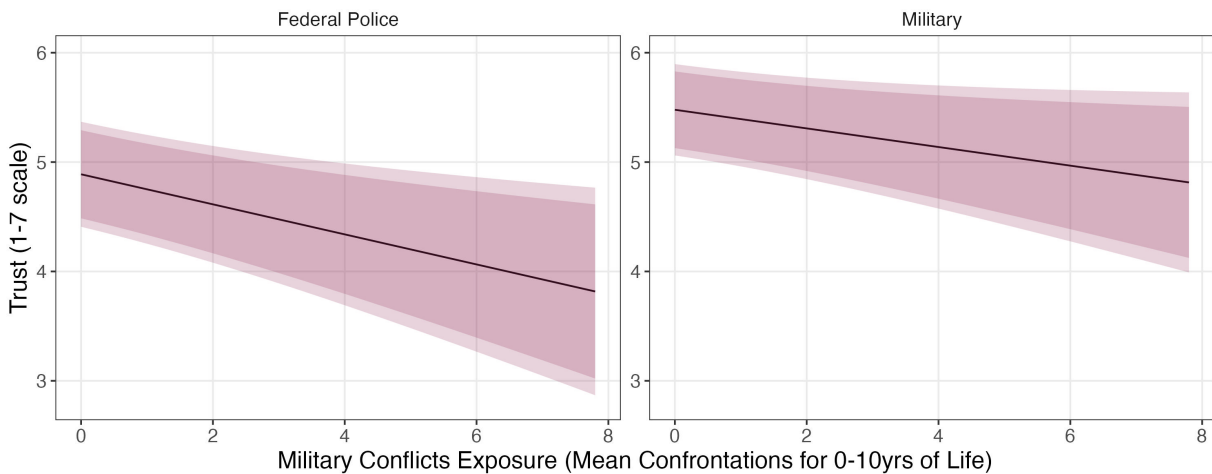
Consistent with our expectations, we find strong and method-consistent evidence that exposure to military confrontations results in the long-term erosion of trust in the military and federal police. By contrast, the negative effect associated with military operations is more method-sensitive and only significant at the $p < 0.1$ level. This suggests that exposure to military presence alone during childhood may not have a prominent effect; instead, violence associated with military confrontations may

¹⁷Results are robust to a more relaxed classification of the eligible cohort (Appendix 15).

be necessary to strongly depress trust later in life.

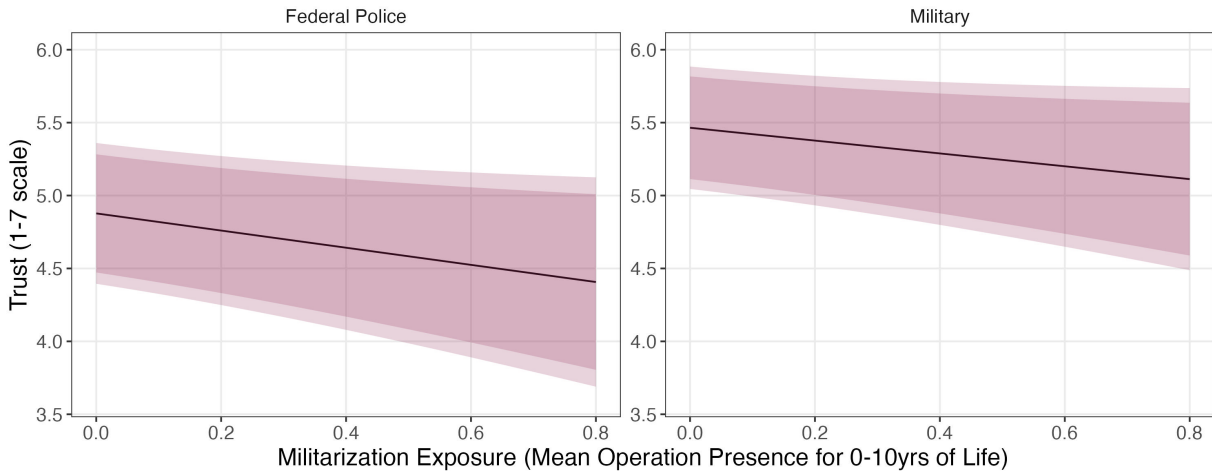
Further, we proposed that trust in the federal government should also suffer from exposure to, at minimum, military confrontations. While the effect is negative, it is only significant in two instances at the $p < 0.1$ level (Tables 4 & 6). To probe this tenuous result, in the subsequent section we evaluate if opinions of the federal government are specifically targeted at officials who are co-partisans of those most responsible for drug war-era violence – namely, the PRI and PAN.

Figure 4: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Decreased Trust



Note: Predicted values from OLS models. Results correspond to models 4 and 5 in Tables 4. Models used to generate predictions do not use standardized DVs or IVs. Shaded regions represent 90% (dark) and 95% (light) CIs.

Figure 5: Exposure to Military Operations and Decreased Trust



Note: Predicted values from OLS models. Results correspond to models 4 and 5 in Tables 5. Models used to generate predictions do not use standardized DVs or IVs. Shaded regions represent 90% (dark) and 95% (light) CIs.

Table 4: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.030)	-0.055* (0.030)	-0.012 (0.033)	-0.078** (0.032)	-0.056** (0.028)	-0.026 (0.029)
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.089	0.084	0.091	0.085	0.094

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 5: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-11yrs)	-0.042 (0.038)	-0.023 (0.036)	-0.009 (0.037)	-0.069* (0.037)	-0.060* (0.036)	-0.042 (0.038)
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.084	0.090	0.084	0.095

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 6: Military Confrontations and Cohort Eligibility

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.027* (0.016)	-0.005 (0.018)	-0.038** (0.017)	-0.030** (0.015)	-0.011 (0.015)
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.085	0.082	0.084	0.080	0.090

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table 7: Military Operations and Cohort Eligibility

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Ops. (2007-11)	-0.099 (0.112)	-0.101 (0.108)	0.017 (0.111)	-0.194* (0.109)	-0.140 (0.108)	-0.090 (0.109)
Controls	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Municipality FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.084	0.082	0.083	0.079	0.090

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Effects on Vote Choice

Results in the previous section suggest that exposure to militarized violence may lead citizens to form more targeted political assessments, rather than broadly eroding trust in government. To further evaluate this, we examine whether individuals exposed to local military engagements during childhood are more likely to penalize politicians affiliated with the parties of the presidents who authorized troop deployments in their communities—Calderón’s PAN and Peña Nieto’s PRI.¹⁸ Voters exposed to violence during childhood and to the continued failure of this strategy under successive governments may have developed generalized skepticism toward both parties, consistent with theories of political socialization that emphasize early-life experiences.

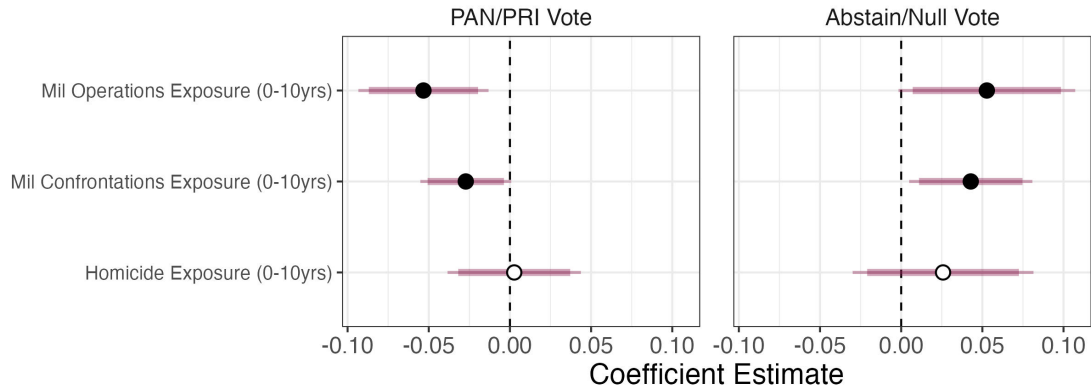
Accordingly, we examine the reported vote choice of voting-aged respondents in our sample ($n = 1,898$), assessing how exposure to lethal criminal violence, military–criminal confrontations, and military operations during the first decade of life shapes support for PAN and PRI candidates in the 2021 legislative election. In these midterm elections, a vote for the PAN or PRI primarily reflected support for each party’s national brand rather than for individual legislative candidates.¹⁹ Because both parties governed during respondents’ childhood years, voters who link those periods to militarization and drug-war violence may penalize both parties across levels of office. Conducted one week after the June 2021 legislative election, our survey allows us to measure recent vote choice with minimal recall error while maximizing the eligible electorate in our sample, as all respondents aged 18 or older by mid-2021 were eligible to vote.

The results presented in Figure 6 provide evidence in support of a backlash against the PAN and PRI in light of exposure to drug war-era military interventions. See Appendix 13 for full results. As exposure to confrontations ($p < 0.1$) and operations ($p < 0.05$) during childhood increases, the probability of voting for the PAN or PRI later in life decreases. Notably, as exposure to lethal violence

¹⁸PAN’s association with the drug war is unambiguous: President Calderón (2006–2012) initiated military deployment and presided over the dramatic escalation of violence, meaning cohorts exposed during early childhood experienced this violence precisely during his presidency. The PRI’s link is less obvious but follows from policy continuity, as Peña Nieto (2012–2018) largely maintained Calderón’s militarized approach despite different rhetoric. See <https://insightcrime.org/news/analysis/mexico-president-reprises-controversial-kingpin-strategy/>, last accessed January 5, 2026.

¹⁹Although Mexico employs a mixed electoral system, party labels remain the primary heuristic in legislative contests.

Figure 6: Effect of Criminal Violence and Military Interventions on Vote Behavior



Note: Coefficients correspond to linear probability models, predicting a PAN/PRI vote (left panel) or vote abstention/null vote (right panel). The main independent variables are standardized. Models include controls for gender, SES, and education, with birth year and municipality fixed effects. Error bars represent 90% (bold) and 95% (thin) CIs.

increases, the PAN/PRI vote probability does not decrease. A one standard deviation increase in exposure to military presence, for example, resulted in a 5% decrease in the likelihood of voting for the PAN or PRI. This supports our argument regarding targeted effects on specific government-led efforts. We also analyze the degree to which this reduced probability of voting for the PAN or PRI translates into increased support for competing parties – namely MORENA – or disengagement with the political system. We find that both exposure to military operations and confrontations is associated with decreased engagement overall, as measured by vote abstention and null voting. As shown in Appendix 13, there is no relationship between exposure and vote for MORENA.

Robustness

We test the robustness of our findings using alternative specifications and additional controls. In our continuous models (Tables 3, 4, 5), we account for pre–drug war trends by controlling for SEDENA drug-trafficking detentions prior to the drug war (Appendix 6), and ensure current violence is not driving results by including the contemporary municipal homicide rate (Appendix 7). We also implement a risk-set matching design (Rosenbaum, 2020), restricting analyses to municipalities on similar exposure paths but with different onset timing (Appendix 11). Finally, we consider the reliability of our results in light of the modifiable areal-unit problem (MAUP) (Lee et al., 2025) by re-estimating exposure using a

respondent’s municipality and all adjacent municipalities (Appendix 8). Across all robustness checks, results remain consistent in sign and typically in significance.

For our results leveraging the exogenous shock of the drug war (Tables 6 & 7), we adopt a more relaxed definition of the eligible cohort, including respondents born as early as 1999. Although this captures some individuals aged 11–12 in 2010–2011 and younger children in 2007–2010, results remain largely unchanged (Appendix 15). Our claim of exogeneity assumes no systematic pre-shock differences between municipalities with high- versus low-levels of military interventions. Consistent with the logic of parallel-trends, we find no pre-drug war differences in drug-trafficking detentions among municipalities first targeted in 2007 (Appendix 14). We also document balance across homicide rates, pre-war detentions, and respondent demographics (Appendix 14), supporting a lack of systematic difference in observable potentially confounding variables.

Conclusion

We document the lasting detrimental effects of Mexico’s drug war on the political attitudes of conflict-exposed children. We provide evidence that exposure to lethal criminal violence and to the government’s militarized security strategy during the first decade of life lowers community and political trust in ways that persist into early adulthood. We also find that childhood exposure to military interventions triggered a political backlash against the PAN and PRI—the parties responsible for implementing these security policies during this generation’s formative years—and heightened political disaffection.

While our focus is on childhood experiences, we acknowledge that exposure to violence at later stages of life also shapes political attitudes (e.g., [Bauer et al., 2016](#); [Pion-Berlin and Carreras, 2017](#); [Ley, 2017](#)). Nevertheless, our central finding is that early-life exposure exerts particularly durable effects. We use the terms “long-lasting” and “persistent” in a precise sense: these effects carry forward from exposure during ages 0–10 to political attitudes measured between ages 16–29, and remain evident even after accounting for contemporaneous violence.

Our study also brings conceptual nuance to research on exposure to militarized conflict. We differentiate between experiences with violent military *confrontations* and with nonviolent military *operations*. While exposure to confrontations produces consistent and sizable decreases in trust, exposure to operations—capturing presence without violence—has weaker and less consistent effects. This dis-

inction highlights that mass deployments alone may not be sufficient to generate long-term changes in opinion; it is the experience of violent confrontation that appears to most undermine trust in related government institutions. These results reinforce the argument that it is childhood exposure to violence, rather than militarization itself, that yields enduring consequences for political attitudes.

We also show that exposure to lethal criminal violence during one's formative years undermines trust in both federal police forces and one's community. This aligns with research demonstrating that violence weakens a community's social fabric (Salmi et al., 2007; Corbacho et al., 2015), while contributing new evidence that these effects persist over time. We also find a negative, although not statistically significant, relationship across all political entities examined. Observing statistically significant decreased trust in the federal police, rather than across government entities, brings a new perspective to the impact of violence on trust that contrasts with earlier research reporting more widespread negative impacts.

Our analysis further demonstrates that childhood exposure to both military confrontations and presence produces electoral consequences. Individuals exposed to these forms of militarization are less likely, years later, to support PAN or PRI candidates—the parties of the presidents who oversaw the bulk of these operations. Notably, we do not find consistent declines in overall trust in the federal government, suggesting that youths attribute responsibility to specific political actors rather than to governing institutions more broadly. While our evidence comes from the 2021 midterm election, these partisan effects may be even stronger in high-salience contests, warranting further research.

These patterns carry important implications for downstream political engagement. Lower interpersonal and institutional trust can diminish individuals' willingness to participate in civic and electoral life, and prior research shows that political participation tends to be lower in high-violence settings (Córdova, 2019; Ley, 2018; Trelles and Carreras, 2012). Our findings suggest one potential mechanism: violence experienced during formative years weakens trust, which in turn may discourage individuals from participating in the political life of their communities (Wollebæk et al., 2012). In contexts where individuals continue to reside in the same communities where they experienced violence—as is common in Mexico and much of Latin America—the erosion of social and political trust may thus have severe and lasting consequences.

Finally, understanding the long-term effects of childhood exposure to violence is essential for de-

signing policies that foster political stability, strengthen democratic norms, and promote social cohesion. This study provides new evidence of the sociopolitical consequences of exposure to criminal violence and militarized security interventions during childhood—an area that remains understudied despite the millions of children growing up amid conflict in the Global South. Further research should examine whether particular forms of violence exposure shape the adoption of specific political ideologies in adulthood and whether the impacts on trust and engagement persist as exposed cohorts age.

Supplementary material. Supplementary material for this article can be found at [Production team to insert link].

Data availability statement. Replication data for this article can be found in the Harvard Dataverse at <https://doi.org/10.7910/DVN/9MNIY3>.

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Competing interests. None to disclose.

Ethical standards. This research went under full review and was approved by The George Washington University Committee on Human Research, Institutional Review Board (IRB), FWA00005945.

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Appendix

The Legacy of Mexico's Drug War on Youth Political Attitudes

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Contents

1	Survey Protocols & Ethics	A2
2	MRP Goodness of Fit Indicators	A5
3	Descriptive Statistics	A8
4	Socioeconomic Status (SES) Variable Creation	A10
5	Main OLS Results	A11
6	Controlling for Pre-Drug War Detentions	A13
7	Controlling for Violence at Time of Survey	A14
8	MAUP and Adjacent Exposure	A16
9	Subgroup Effects: SES & Education	A18
10	Movers & Trust	A21
11	Risk-Set Matching	A21
12	Disentangling Effects of Confrontations vs. Operations	A22
13	Partisan Effects Results	A25
14	Quasi-Experimental Design: Balance & Pre-Trends	A26
15	Quasi-Experimental Results with Expansion of Exposure Cohort	A27

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1 Survey Protocols & Ethics

Our survey was fielded in partnership with our local partner, Buendía & Marquez, based in Mexico City, Mexico. The survey was fielded as part of the larger Performance Evaluation of USAID/Mexico's Crime and Violence Prevention Activity. The survey was reviewed by the Institutional Review Board at George Washington University (FWA00005945), and received approval. The study was conducted in compliance with all local Mexican laws and regulations, in addition to ethical standards contained in the 1964 Declaration of Helsinki, including its amendments.

Survey Format and Recruitment

The survey was conducted face-to-face with structured questionnaires by trained interviews who used personal tablets. Interviewers followed all local COVID-19 protocols and maintained social distance from interviewees. Once a survey was complete, responses were immediately uploaded to the cloud and removed from the tablet to ensure sensitive information would not be at risk of disclosure. All completed questionnaires were checked during and after fieldwork for quality control. Interviewers also worked in teams of three with a supervisor whose responsibility was to monitor quality and make any necessary adjustments.

To recruit survey participants, enumerators follow a random selection process detailed in the following section. Once participants are selected, the enumerator invites a participant in the household to participate in the survey completely voluntarily. Subjects were told they could decline to participate or end their participation in the survey at any time. Enumerators required verbal consent to participate from the respondents following a consent text. Consent was not requested from parents, as we did not interview youths under the age of 16. Participants may have responded differently (and bias results) during interviews if they knew their parents needed to consent. Further, some answers regarding behavior among youth, such as entertainment and attitudes towards crime in the community, were likely to be influenced by parental approval.

We did not offer compensation for participation in the survey, which is standard among short in-person surveys in the region (e.g., the Latin American Public Opinion Project at Vanderbilt University). Surveys took on average about 20 minutes of respondents' time. Although respondents were not offered monetary compensation, they were told of the possible benefits of participation. These included voicing concerns regarding violence in their communities and how the results from our study could help develop a deeper understanding regarding insecurity dynamics in the localities where the surveyed individuals live. The project was also conducted in conjunction with USAID, and was aimed to better design crime prevention efforts in Mexico, which would positively impact research subjects.

No methods of deception were included in our survey, nor was identifiable information collected regarding any of the participants. The research involved no more than minimal risk to subjects, the investigators and research staff apart from possible discomfort when responding to some questions. However, participants were warned of this risk and the consent process emphasized the option for respondents to end the survey at any time if they wished.

Sampling Design

The survey was designed to achieve a nationally representative sample of urban Mexico for ages 16-29. In addition, the survey was designed to be representative of certain security realities

(homicide, perceived insecurity, and victimization). To do so, a multistage area probability sampling design was used. Respondents were selected using a four stage sampling process. Stage 1 involved the selection of primary sampling units (PSUs), which in this case were electoral sections - a small geographic jurisdiction in Mexico that is smaller than the municipality. They constitute the basic territorial unit of single-member electoral districts for citizens to register to vote. As of March 2021, Mexico was divided into 68,806 electoral sections.

To select PSUs, the sampling frame was limited to Mexican municipalities which were covered by the Encuesta Nacional de Seguridad Pública Urbana (ENSU, National Urban Public Security Survey) run by Mexico's national statistical institute, the Instituto Nacional de Estadística y Geografía (INEGI). This survey is representative of urban Mexico and includes important public security information that was used later in the sampling process. From this, the number of PSUs eligible to be included in our survey was reduced to 30,878. We supplemented this list of municipalities and PSUs with additional information from the November 2020 Geoelectoral Information Catalog from INEGI and the 2020 Census to create our final sampling frame.

We supplemented the sampling frame with additional information regarding three measures of security realities in Mexico. We added three municipal-level measures of violence. These were homicide rates as reported by the Executive Secretariat of the National System of Public Security (SESNSP), a measure of perceived community security, and a measure of victimization. In Mexico, homicide data are available from two sources - via the SESNSP reflecting police investigations, and via INEGI from death certificates. Although INEGI data tends to be more precise, the publication of this data is usually delayed by over a year. Because of this, we use SESNSP data which covered the entirety of 2020 at the municipal level. We only use data regarding intentional homicides.

The latter two measures were generated using responses from the ENSU survey. Given that the ENSU data are not representative at the municipal level, we generated municipal estimates using multilevel regression and poststratification (MRP). To do so, we brought in additional information from the 2015 intercensus. These measures capture the preponderance of nonhomicidal crime (victimization) and perceived community insecurity at the municipal level. In particular, we used the following questions from the ENSU survey:

- **Perceived Security:** In terms of crime, do you consider that to live in (CITY) currently is ... [safe, unsafe]? *En términos de la delincuencia, ¿considera que vivir actualmente en (CIUDAD), es ... [seguro, inseguro]?*
- **Victimization:** During the past year [insert year], that is to say from January to today, has a member of your household (including yourself) been victim of (INSERT TYPE OF CRIME) on card A? *Durante este año [insert year], es decir, de enero a la fecha, ¿algún integrante de este hogar incluído usted, sufrieron la situación (CÓDIGO DE INCIDENCIA) de la tarjeta A?*
 - Robbery or assault in the street or in public transportation? Yes or No. *Robo o asalto en la calle o en el transporte público (incluye robo en banco o cajero automático)? Sí o No?*
 - Threats, pressure, or deception to demand money or goods or to do something/ not to do something (extortion, blackmail)? Yes or No? *Amenazas, presiones, o engaños para exigir dinero o bienes; o para que hiciera algo o dejara de hacerlo (extorsión)? Sí o No?*

For the first measure, perceived security, we coded the variable as 1 if an individual reported feeling "insecure" and 0 if an individual reported feeling "secure" in their city. For our second

measure, victimization, we coded the variable as 1 if the individual reported that a member of their household had either experienced robbery or extortion in the past year and coded 0 if not.

With these questions, we then estimated the relationship between various individual-level characteristics and their responses on these selected survey questions. We did this through multilevel regression, where we determined the relationship between selected characteristics—in this case age, gender, education, and occupation—and reported (i) insecurity and (ii) household victimization. This involved two separate regression models, one for each outcome variable. The regression also factored in geographic location, with individuals' municipalities (unrepresentative unit of interest) nested within their states (geographic unit of the survey).

Once these regression estimates were calculated, we then post-stratified them. This involved weighting our estimates by the prevalence of each type of individual within each municipality based on their individual-level characteristics (i.e., age, education, etc.). This "prevalence" was calculated by determining the population of each type of individual within a municipality according to the 2015 intercensus. The regression estimates, weighted in this manner, generated a municipal-level estimate (one for each municipality) for the most likely response to each of the two survey questions.

Through this process, we calculated two municipal-level estimates: one quantifying non-homicidal victimization and the other quantifying residents' perception of community security in their municipality. We calculated these values for all municipalities included in the most recent ENSU survey, yielding estimates for 157 municipalities. These values can be interpreted as a ranking of perceived security and victimization among the municipalities we examined. They allowed us to determine within our sample of municipalities how they rank comparatively in terms of these two values. However, these measures do have error associated with them and cannot be compared to estimates outside of these analyses. This error was predominantly created by limitations due to question wording and the need to match variables between the census and survey. We had to match individual-level responses on the ENSU survey to biographical information about the head of household, as certain attributes were only recorded at the head-of-household level (e.g., education level, occupation) in this survey. We used these head-of-household characteristics when considering the prevalence of each type of individual in the intercensus. Thus, these measures are not perfect individual-level measures, but did provide us with comparable intersample estimates. For this reason, we interpreted them as a ranking. For more information regarding the MRP indicators, see Appendix 1.2.

These measures were then added to our sampling frame for their corresponding municipalities and PSUs. Our sample of PSUs were then selected for the sample through a systematic method of stratified probability proportional to size (PPS). Each PSU in the sampling frame was also assigned a nonoverlapping sample stratum based on the three security variables. We combined PPS with a systematic sampling approach and used implicit stratification (via a travelling salesperson algorithm) based on the three violence measures. Survey sample strata information can be seen in Table A1. In total, 288 PSUs were selected and 10 interviews was conducted in each PSU.

Within each strata available, electoral precincts, our primarily sampling unit (PSU) were chosen based on the probability proportional to each precinct's size (PPS). In all, 288 electoral sections were selected from the sampling frame and 10 interviews were conducted in each.

In some cases, PSUs were not available to conduct interviews due to various circumstances, including security concerns for interviewers. In such cases, a new PSU with the same stratum characteristics and probability of selection was drawn from an independent sample.

With this sample of PSUs, area segments sampling was then used to select second-stage

Table A1: Strata Information for Sample Frame and Implicit Samples

Strata	Frame Mun #	Frame Mun Prop	Frame Mun Pop	Frame Pop Prop	Sample Avg Muns	Sample Mun Pop	Sample Pop Prop
Med-Low-Low	10	0.06	1641492	0.04	5.00	35179.00	0.04
Med-High-High	19	0.12	8489648	0.19	15.50	129172.00	0.14
Med-High-Low	11	0.07	5328138	0.12	7.00	115145.50	0.12
High-Low-Low	1	0.01	18812	0.00	1.00	768.00	0.00
High-High-High	12	0.08	3624341	0.08	10.00	92593.00	0.10
High-High-Low	28	0.18	11204188	0.25	24.00	249390.50	0.27
Low-Low-High	1	0.01	231209	0.01	1.00	1107.00	0.00
Low-Low-Low	46	0.29	8313862	0.18	27.00	188532.00	0.20
Low-High-High	15	0.10	3192100	0.07	7.00	42893.00	0.05
Low-High-Low	14	0.09	3418396	0.08	9.00	67989.00	0.07

Figure Note: Strata listed in terms homicide rate, perceived insecurity, and reported victimization from left to right.

sampling units (SSUs). We used blocks as our SSUs, or geographic spaces delimited by streets or avenues. SSUs were identified and assigned to interviews using maps from the Instituto Nacional Electoral (INE, National Electoral Institute). Within each PSU, two SSUs were selected via a random sample from INE's Catálogo de Manzanas (a catalog of small geographic subdivisions called "manzanas").

Once the SSUs were selected, housing units were then chosen which represented our final sampling unit. Five interviews were conducted per SSU. Housing units were selected via a spiral method and clockwise walking. Interviewers cover each block by starting at the northeast corner and use a sampling interval of 3 housing units. Once an interview is completed, the interviewer moves to the other side of the block, ensuring that only one interview is conducted on each side of the block. Then, interviewers moved to an adjacent block using the spiral method. In multi-story buildings, the same process was utilized but only when a building occupies a whole block. If a building is located on one side of the block, only one interview may take place inside the building. After such an interview, interviewers must move on from both the building and side of the block.

Once housing units were selected, an individual is then selected by the interviewer. A short screening interview was conducted with a knowledgeable adult to determine if members of the household meet the study eligibility criteria. With the information provided by the present adult, the tablet then picks a respondent from the total pool of eligible household inhabitants. The interviewer then asks to speak to that individual.

In total, 64 interviewers were used to complete the survey. 2,880 interviews were completed over nine days between June 12 and June 20, 2021.

2 MRP Goodness of Fit Indicators

In this section, we demonstrate information which confirms the adequacy of our MRP indicators. First, we demonstrate the correlations between our two MRP measures and the true values (means) of the variables we used to create these measures (victimization and perceived security). High, but not perfect, correlation would indicate a strong MRP estimate. This is shown in Figure A1, which confirms that our MRP estimates and the true values are highly correlated (for those municipalities for which we had a representative estimator). We also see a correlation between homicide rates and MRP insecurity perception estimates, but a nearly zero correlation between homicide rates and MRP victimization estimates. We observe a high correlation between MRP security and victimization estimates.

To further explore these results, we ran mixed-effects models with random intercepts by state. Results are shown in Figure A2, on which population, homicide, and homicide rate are

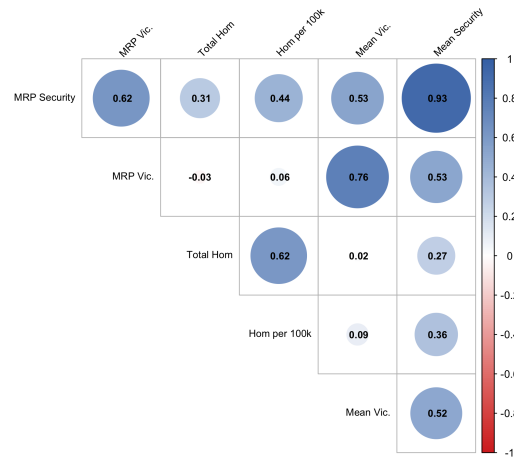


Figure A1: Correlations between MRP Estimates and True Values (Means)

rescaled as values ranging from 0 to 1.

For the security measures on Table 1, as the population increases, so does insecurity. As the homicide rate increases, so does the insecurity index. Total homicide does not have a significant relationship with this index. In terms of the victimization index, there is little relationship with the included variables (the coefficient sizes are very small and confidence intervals cross zero). As population increases, the victimization index increases slightly. However, total homicide and homicide rate do not have significant relationships with victimization index, as confidence intervals include zero in both cases. From this analysis, we observe that in urban Mexico, there are places with homicide violence but not much other violence and vice versa, and there does seem to be little correlation between homicide rates and victimization estimates. There are correlations between homicide rates and security perceptions, although these are not high. Therefore, we divided the sampling units (using the ENSU sample) by levels of homicide, nonhomicidal violence (victimization), and insecurity perception.

Figure A3 provides ROC (receiver operating characteristic) curves for the multi-level models used in the MRP process. This curve demonstrates the ability of the models to correctly predict outcomes, with the x-y line indicating a “null model.” It can be considered a measure of sensitivity (probability of detection) versus specificity (probability of false detection) and is essentially a plot of the model’s power as a function of Type 1 error (rejection of true null hypothesis, false positive). Both plots below indicate the models perform better than the null model, providing evidence of their strength for prediction of both outcomes of interest (victimization and perceived security).

<i>Predictors</i>	Security 2020			Vic. 2020		
	<i>Estimates</i>	<i>CI</i>	<i>p</i>	<i>Estimates</i>	<i>CI</i>	<i>p</i>
Intercept	5.88	-20.35 – 32.11	0.658	5.62	-1.38 – 12.62	0.115
Log Population	4.03	1.98 – 6.08	<0.001	0.69	0.16 – 1.23	0.011
Hom. Total	6.32	-21.14 – 33.78	0.650	1.40	-5.91 – 8.70	0.706
Hom. Per 100k	28.13	7.50 – 48.76	0.008	1.44	-4.14 – 7.02	0.611
Random Effects						
σ^2	106.15			6.74		
τ_{00}	181.22 _{state_code}			31.08 _{state_code}		
ICC	0.63			0.82		
N	32 _{state_code}			32 _{state_code}		
Observations	157			157		
Marginal R ² / Conditional R ²	0.208 / 0.708			0.036 / 0.828		

Figure A2: MRP Estimates, Homicide, and Population at the Municipal Level

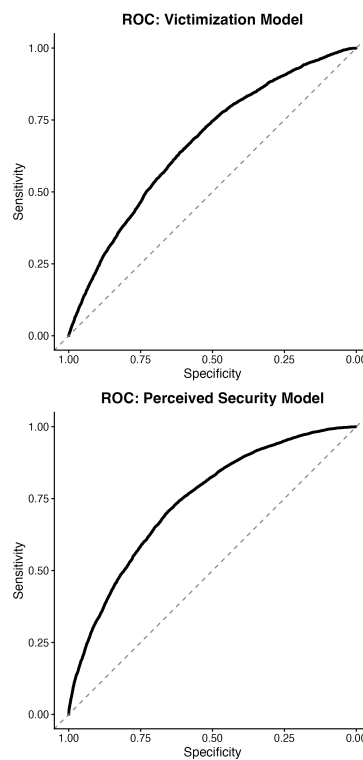


Figure A3: Receiver Operating Characteristic Curves for Multilevel Models

3 Descriptive Statistics

In this section, we provide descriptive statistics for our survey, including sociodemographic and economic indicators. As our analysis focuses on respondents who have not moved residences, we provide descriptive statistics only for these individuals.

Table A2: Sex, Age, and Education Breakdown

Sex	Mean Age	Mode Edu	Num. Respondents
Male	21.25	Preparatoria o bachillerato	1130
Female	22.14	Preparatoria o bachillerato	1295

Table A3: Employment Status in the Past Week

Type	% Respondents
Did not work	6.27
Had a job but did not work	1.65
Household work	14.93
Looked for work	5.44
Permanently unable to work	0.78
Student	27.09
Worked	42.89
NA/No Response	0.95

In addition, we provide information as to the typical presence of military conflict and operations, including repeated operations, in our sample municipalities vs. urban municipalities across Mexico. In Figure A4, we plot the mean presence of military conflict (binary), military operations (binary), and repeat operations (one or more) for the 2007-2015 period across all municipalities in our sample compared to all of urban Mexico, as determined by municipalities included in the ENSU survey (which is representative of urban Mexico). We plot 2007-2015, as 2007 is the start of deployments in the drug war, and 2015 is the last exposure year in our analytical strategy (as it represents the 10th year of life for our youngest participants, born in 2005).

To be sure, operations and repeat operations were more common on average in our sample compared to broader Mexico. However, this is likely explained by differences in population, with our sample having a mean population of 768,342 in 2007 and the urban ENSU sample having a mean of 540,088. Further, our analytical strategy focuses on differential exposure over time, comparing not only individuals across space but also across age groups. As shown in the main text, we have substantial variation in exposure across our surveyed individuals.

Further, we also show that municipal-level homicide rates – both within and outside of our sample municipalities – are highly correlated with disappearances, a form of violence that is less visible but commonly used by criminal organizations in Mexico (Durán-Martínez, 2017). Data on disappearances comes from the National Registry of Missing or Disappeared Persons (RNPED, *Registro Nacional de Datos de Personas Extraviadas o Desaparecidas*). At the time of writing, links on this website to access the data were non-functioning. We are grateful to [ANONYMIZED NAME] for sharing their previously collected data from this source from 1995-2018. With this data, we run a two-way fixed effects regression (by municipality and year) examining the rela-

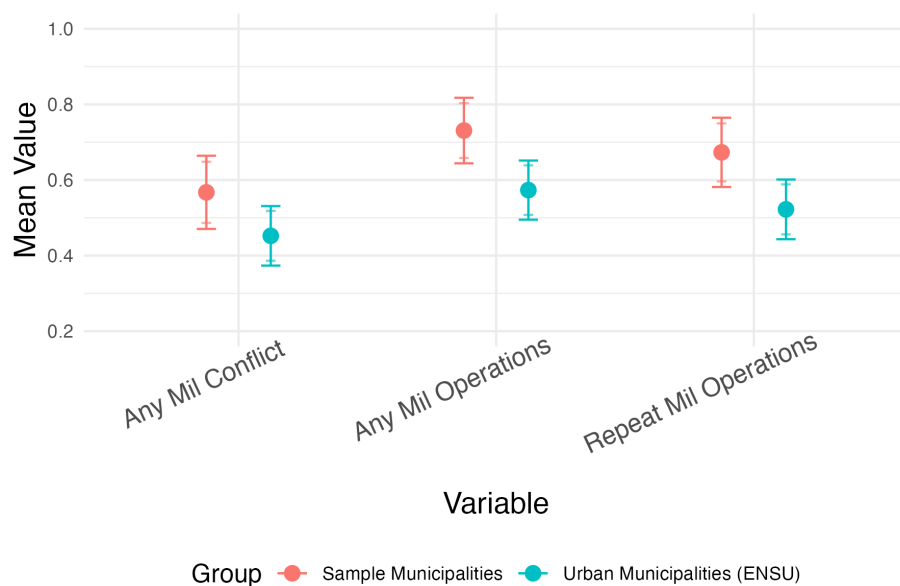


Figure A4: Average Military Operations and Conflict Across Sample and Urban Municipalities (2007-2015)

relationship between the municipal homicide and disappearance rate. Results presented in Figure A4 reveal a close to perfect relationship between these two measures.

Table A4: Relationship Between Homicide Rate and Disappearances across Sample and All Municipalities (1995-2018)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>	
	Homicide Rate (per 100k)	
	All Muns	Sample Muns
	(1)	(2)
Disappearance Rate (per 100k)	0.998*** (0.027)	0.936*** (0.090)
Mun FE	✓	✓
Year FE	✓	✓
Observations	58,896	2,496
R ²	0.258	0.488
Adjusted R ²	0.225	0.461
<i>Note:</i>	*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01	

4 Socioeconomic Status (SES) Variable Creation

To create the variable which we use to measure socioeconomic status (SES), we rely on a battery of questions regarding the possession of certain material goods (see Table A5). We then use these questions to create one variable measuring SES using principal component analysis (PCA). We use the first calculated component which explains the most variance (over 30 %) across participants (see Figure A5). Not all participants responded to each question regarding possession of each good – to fill in these gaps, we used multiple imputation using predictive mean matching (PMM) (see Heitjan and Little (1991); Little (1988)), implemented via the Multiple Imputation by Chained Equations (MICE) package in R (Van Buuren and Groothuis-Oudshoorn, 2011). This process resulted in a variable which has a maximum value of 2.56, minimum value of 0, and mean value of 1.94.

Table A5: Items Included in Socioeconomic Status Variable and Descriptive Statistics

Please tell me if you or a member of your household has CURRENT access to each of the following services in your home (Yes = 1, No = 0):	Minimum	Median	Mean	Max	NA's
Car	0	1	0.58	1	21
Cell Phone	0	1	0.94	1	22
Computer	0	1	0.64	1	23
Internet	0	1	0.87	1	26
Indoor Plumbing	0	1	0.94	1	24
Clothes Washer	0	1	0.88	1	22
Domestic Worker	0	0	0.26	1	27

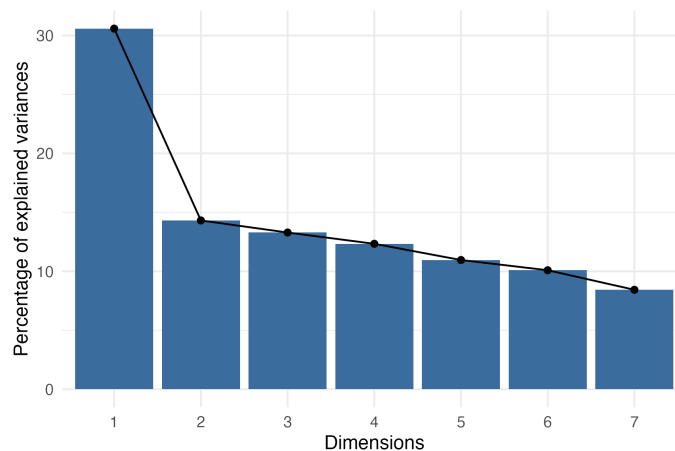


Figure A5: PCA Variance Explained

5 Main OLS Results

Table A6: Exposure to Homicide and Trust

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.041)	-0.041 (0.040)	-0.046 (0.038)	-0.087** (0.040)	-0.024 (0.046)	-0.084** (0.037)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.030 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.042)	-0.205*** (0.043)	-0.175*** (0.042)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.092* (0.048)	-0.112** (0.048)	0.050 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.032** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.061*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.085	0.090	0.083	0.096
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.037	0.043	0.035	0.049
Residual Std. Error	0.978 (df = 2281)	0.980 (df = 2281)	0.981 (df = 2280)	0.978 (df = 2284)	0.983 (df = 2270)	0.975 (df = 2286)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A7: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.030)	-0.055* (0.030)	-0.012 (0.033)	-0.078** (0.032)	-0.056** (0.028)	-0.026 (0.029)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.045 (0.043)	-0.206*** (0.043)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.121** (0.048)	-0.051 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.093* (0.048)	-0.114** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.089	0.084	0.091	0.085	0.094
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.041	0.036	0.043	0.036	0.047
Residual Std. Error	0.978 (df = 2281)	0.979 (df = 2281)	0.981 (df = 2280)	0.978 (df = 2284)	0.982 (df = 2270)	0.976 (df = 2286)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A8: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.042 (0.038)	-0.023 (0.036)	-0.009 (0.037)	-0.069* (0.037)	-0.060* (0.036)	-0.042 (0.038)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.110*** (0.043)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.047 (0.043)	-0.209*** (0.043)	-0.175*** (0.043)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.092* (0.048)	-0.113** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.084	0.090	0.084	0.095
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.036	0.042	0.036	0.047
Residual Std. Error	0.978 (df = 2281)	0.980 (df = 2281)	0.981 (df = 2280)	0.978 (df = 2284)	0.982 (df = 2270)	0.976 (df = 2286)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A9: Confrontations X Cohort Eligibility

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.027* (0.016)	-0.005 (0.018)	-0.038** (0.017)	-0.030** (0.015)	-0.011 (0.015)
Cohort: Eligible	-0.042 (0.084)	0.038 (0.086)	0.070 (0.084)	0.131 (0.086)	0.050 (0.085)	0.045 (0.081)
Gender: Female	-0.112*** (0.043)	-0.108** (0.043)	-0.032 (0.043)	-0.044 (0.042)	-0.206*** (0.042)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.119** (0.048)	-0.053 (0.048)	-0.065 (0.047)	-0.095** (0.048)	-0.113** (0.047)	0.047 (0.049)
Edu	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.033** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	-0.037*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.063*** (0.013)
Age	-0.045*** (0.010)	-0.016 (0.010)	-0.031*** (0.010)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.015 (0.010)	0.007 (0.010)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.085	0.082	0.084	0.080	0.090
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.041	0.038	0.041	0.036	0.047
Residual Std. Error	0.977 (df = 2292)	0.979 (df = 2292)	0.980 (df = 2291)	0.979 (df = 2295)	0.982 (df = 2281)	0.975 (df = 2297)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A10: Operations X Cohort Eligibility

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Ops (2007-11)	-0.099 (0.112)	-0.101 (0.108)	0.017 (0.111)	-0.194* (0.109)	-0.140 (0.108)	-0.090 (0.109)
Cohort: Eligible	-0.035 (0.090)	0.035 (0.092)	0.057 (0.091)	0.146 (0.092)	0.057 (0.092)	0.062 (0.088)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.109** (0.043)	-0.031 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.042)	-0.207*** (0.042)	-0.175*** (0.042)
SES	-0.118** (0.048)	-0.051 (0.048)	-0.065 (0.047)	-0.093* (0.048)	-0.111** (0.047)	0.048 (0.049)
Edu	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.033** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	-0.038*** (0.013)	-0.016 (0.013)	0.063*** (0.013)
Age	-0.045*** (0.010)	-0.017* (0.010)	-0.031*** (0.010)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.015 (0.010)	0.007 (0.010)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.084	0.082	0.083	0.079	0.090
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.040	0.038	0.040	0.035	0.047
Residual Std. Error	0.978 (df = 2292)	0.980 (df = 2292)	0.980 (df = 2291)	0.979 (df = 2295)	0.983 (df = 2281)	0.975 (df = 2297)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

6 Controlling for Pre-Drug War Detentions

Here, we present models that control for detentions in respondents' birth municipality by SEDENA prior to the official start of the Drug War. This variable is calculated as the average number of drug-trafficking related detentions between 2000 and 2005.

Table A11: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (including pre-Drug War Detentions)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.031 (0.043)	-0.035 (0.041)	-0.055 (0.040)	-0.079* (0.041)	0.005 (0.048)	-0.089** (0.039)
Gender: Female	-0.090* (0.052)	-0.086* (0.052)	-0.037 (0.052)	-0.039 (0.050)	-0.182*** (0.050)	-0.154*** (0.052)
SES	-0.095 (0.058)	0.005 (0.057)	-0.051 (0.056)	-0.106* (0.054)	-0.088* (0.053)	0.095 (0.059)
Edu	-0.035** (0.016)	-0.051*** (0.016)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.034** (0.015)	-0.014 (0.015)	0.057*** (0.016)
Mean Pre-Drug War Detentions	1.435 (1.858)	-1.944 (2.985)	2.400 (2.047)	1.206 (2.075)	1.405 (2.526)	0.109 (2.918)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,705	1,706	1,707	1,708	1,697	1,710
R ²	0.087	0.088	0.088	0.094	0.072	0.101
Adjusted R ²	0.040	0.040	0.040	0.047	0.024	0.055

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A12: Exposure to Confrontations and Trust (including pre-Drug War Detentions)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.032 (0.032)	-0.049 (0.032)	-0.018 (0.035)	-0.070** (0.034)	-0.036 (0.030)	-0.025 (0.030)
Gender: Female	-0.089* (0.052)	-0.085* (0.052)	-0.035 (0.052)	-0.036 (0.050)	-0.182*** (0.050)	-0.151*** (0.052)
SES	-0.096* (0.058)	0.004 (0.057)	-0.051 (0.056)	-0.108** (0.054)	-0.090* (0.053)	0.096 (0.059)
Edu	-0.036** (0.016)	-0.051*** (0.016)	-0.021 (0.016)	-0.035** (0.015)	-0.013 (0.015)	0.056*** (0.016)
Mean Pre-Drug War Detentions	1.473 (1.862)	-1.909 (2.961)	2.484 (2.037)	1.306 (2.064)	1.379 (2.508)	0.246 (2.911)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,705	1,706	1,707	1,708	1,697	1,710
R ²	0.088	0.089	0.087	0.094	0.073	0.099
Adjusted R ²	0.040	0.041	0.039	0.047	0.025	0.052

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A13: Exposure to Operations and Trust (including pre-Drug War Detentions)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.023 (0.046)	-0.020 (0.044)	-0.010 (0.046)	-0.073* (0.044)	-0.034 (0.043)	-0.037 (0.046)
Gender: Female	-0.090* (0.052)	-0.085* (0.052)	-0.036 (0.052)	-0.039 (0.050)	-0.184*** (0.050)	-0.152*** (0.052)
SES	-0.095 (0.058)	0.006 (0.057)	-0.050 (0.056)	-0.105* (0.055)	-0.089* (0.053)	0.097* (0.059)
Edu	-0.036** (0.016)	-0.051*** (0.016)	-0.021 (0.016)	-0.035** (0.015)	-0.013 (0.015)	0.056*** (0.016)
Mean Pre-Drug War Detentions	1.482 (1.856)	-1.890 (3.010)	2.490 (2.053)	1.321 (2.104)	1.388 (2.567)	0.248 (2.947)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,705	1,706	1,707	1,708	1,697	1,710
R ²	0.087	0.087	0.087	0.093	0.073	0.099
Adjusted R ²	0.040	0.040	0.039	0.046	0.024	0.052

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

7 Controlling for Violence at Time of Survey

This section provides results from main analysis conducted, but including an additional control variable for the homicide rate the year prior to the fielding of the survey. This variable is calculated as the average number of homicides per 100 thousand residents in each municipality.

Table A14: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (including Contemporary Homicide Rate)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.041)	-0.041 (0.040)	-0.046 (0.038)	-0.087** (0.040)	-0.024 (0.046)	-0.084** (0.037)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.005 (0.007)	0.008 (0.012)	-0.009 (0.008)	-0.005 (0.008)	-0.005 (0.010)	0.0003 (0.012)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.030 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.042)	-0.205*** (0.043)	-0.175*** (0.042)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.092* (0.048)	-0.112** (0.048)	0.050 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.032** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.061*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.085	0.090	0.083	0.096
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.037	0.043	0.035	0.049

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A15: Exposure to Mil Confrontations and Trust (including Contemporary Homicide Rate)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.030)	-0.055* (0.030)	-0.012 (0.033)	-0.078** (0.032)	-0.056** (0.028)	-0.026 (0.029)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.005 (0.007)	0.008 (0.012)	-0.009 (0.008)	-0.006 (0.008)	-0.006 (0.010)	-0.0002 (0.012)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.045 (0.043)	-0.206*** (0.043)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.121** (0.048)	-0.051 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.093* (0.048)	-0.114** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.089	0.084	0.091	0.085	0.094
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.041	0.036	0.043	0.036	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A16: Exposure to Mil Operations and Trust (including Contemporary Homicide Rate)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.042 (0.038)	-0.023 (0.036)	-0.009 (0.037)	-0.069* (0.037)	-0.060* (0.036)	-0.042 (0.038)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.005 (0.007)	0.008 (0.012)	-0.009 (0.008)	-0.006 (0.008)	-0.006 (0.010)	-0.0002 (0.012)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.110*** (0.043)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.047 (0.043)	-0.209*** (0.043)	-0.175*** (0.043)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.092* (0.048)	-0.113** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.084	0.090	0.084	0.095
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.036	0.042	0.036	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A17: Confrontations X Cohort Eligibility (including Contemporary Homicide Rate)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.027* (0.016)	-0.005 (0.018)	-0.038** (0.017)	-0.030** (0.015)	-0.011 (0.015)
Cohort: Eligible	-0.042 (0.084)	0.038 (0.086)	0.070 (0.084)	0.131 (0.086)	0.050 (0.085)	0.045 (0.081)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.009 (0.012)	-0.009 (0.008)	-0.005 (0.008)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.001 (0.012)
Gender: Female	-0.112*** (0.043)	-0.108** (0.043)	-0.032 (0.043)	-0.044 (0.042)	-0.206*** (0.042)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.119** (0.048)	-0.053 (0.048)	-0.065 (0.047)	-0.095** (0.048)	-0.113** (0.047)	0.047 (0.049)
Edu	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.033** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	-0.037*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.063*** (0.013)
Age	-0.045*** (0.010)	-0.016 (0.010)	-0.031*** (0.010)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.015 (0.010)	0.007 (0.010)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.085	0.082	0.084	0.080	0.090
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.041	0.038	0.041	0.036	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A18: Operations X Cohort Eligibility (including Contemporary Homicide Rate)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.099 (0.112)	-0.101 (0.108)	0.017 (0.111)	-0.194* (0.109)	-0.140 (0.108)	-0.090 (0.109)
Cohort: Eligible	-0.035 (0.090)	0.035 (0.092)	0.057 (0.091)	0.146 (0.092)	0.057 (0.092)	0.062 (0.088)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.004 (0.007)	0.009 (0.012)	-0.009 (0.008)	-0.005 (0.009)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.001 (0.012)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.109** (0.043)	-0.031 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.042)	-0.207*** (0.042)	-0.175*** (0.042)
SES	-0.118** (0.048)	-0.051 (0.048)	-0.065 (0.047)	-0.093* (0.048)	-0.111** (0.047)	0.048 (0.049)
Edu	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.033** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	-0.038*** (0.013)	-0.016 (0.013)	0.063*** (0.013)
Age	-0.045*** (0.010)	-0.017* (0.010)	-0.031*** (0.010)	-0.005 (0.010)	-0.015 (0.010)	0.007 (0.010)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.084	0.082	0.083	0.079	0.090
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.040	0.038	0.040	0.035	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

8 MAUP and Adjacent Exposure

This section provides results from main analysis conducted, but re-specifying the unit of treatment at a higher level of geographic aggregation. In this way, we consider both how exposure in adjacent municipalities may influence attitudes, and provide a robustness check for issues related to the modifiable areal unit problem (MAUP) (Lee, Rogers and Soifer, 2025). To do so, we identify the geographic unit of interest as the respondent's municipality of residence plus all adjacent municipalities. That is to say, we calculate the same exposure variables for each birth-year-municipality cohort, but including information regarding violence, confrontations, or operations in municipalities contiguous to and including their own. To calculate this variable, we utilize shape files from INEGI to identify all adjacent municipalities to those included in our survey. With this information, we calculate average exposure to the three variables of information for each birth-year-municipality cohort.

Table A19: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (including Adjacent Exposure)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Hom. Adjacent Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.017 (0.042)	-0.007 (0.040)	-0.028 (0.040)	-0.067* (0.040)	-0.008 (0.048)	-0.073* (0.038)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.109** (0.043)	-0.030 (0.043)	-0.047 (0.043)	-0.205*** (0.043)	-0.177*** (0.042)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.049 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.091* (0.048)	-0.112** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.039*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.085	0.090	0.083	0.096
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.036	0.042	0.035	0.048

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A20: Exposure to Mil Confrontations and Trust (including Adjacent Exposure)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Conf Adjacent Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.074** (0.032)	-0.066** (0.031)	-0.051 (0.032)	-0.098*** (0.030)	-0.076*** (0.029)	-0.021 (0.032)
Gender: Female	-0.110*** (0.043)	-0.110** (0.043)	-0.029 (0.043)	-0.044 (0.042)	-0.205*** (0.043)	-0.172*** (0.042)
SES	-0.121** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.092* (0.048)	-0.113** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.025* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.040*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.093	0.089	0.085	0.092	0.086	0.094
Adjusted R ²	0.045	0.042	0.037	0.045	0.037	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A21: Exposure to Mil Operations and Trust (including Adjacent Exposure)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Ops Adjacent Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.023 (0.038)	-0.004 (0.036)	0.010 (0.038)	-0.055 (0.036)	-0.051 (0.034)	-0.026 (0.037)
Gender: Female	-0.111*** (0.043)	-0.109** (0.043)	-0.028 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.043)	-0.207*** (0.043)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.049 (0.048)	-0.068 (0.047)	-0.091* (0.048)	-0.113** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.024* (0.013)	-0.033** (0.014)	-0.012 (0.013)	-0.040*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.060*** (0.013)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.091	0.088	0.084	0.089	0.084	0.094
Adjusted R ²	0.043	0.040	0.036	0.041	0.035	0.047

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

9 Subgroup Effects: SES & Education

In this section, we present results of our analysis but examining subgroups based on socioeconomic status and education levels. We define high and low levels of socioeconomic status based on the median value. For education, we examine those who have completed high school and above (high education) and those who have not (low education). Due to smaller sample sizes, we are unable to consistently estimate robust standard errors; we present conventional standard errors as a result.

Table A22: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (High SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.072 (0.053)	-0.127** (0.053)	0.026 (0.054)	-0.144*** (0.054)	-0.091* (0.055)	-0.098* (0.052)
Gender: Female	-0.193*** (0.058)	-0.165*** (0.058)	-0.126** (0.058)	-0.086 (0.058)	-0.277*** (0.060)	-0.170*** (0.056)
Edu	-0.034* (0.019)	-0.056*** (0.019)	-0.016 (0.019)	-0.045** (0.019)	-0.066*** (0.020)	0.034* (0.019)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,197	1,196	1,197	1,198	1,191	1,199
R ²	0.166	0.164	0.137	0.139	0.160	0.123

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A23: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (Low SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.026 (0.054)	0.015 (0.054)	-0.122** (0.055)	-0.046 (0.054)	0.024 (0.054)	-0.065 (0.056)
Gender: Female	-0.043 (0.063)	-0.081 (0.063)	0.041 (0.063)	-0.034 (0.063)	-0.155** (0.062)	-0.182*** (0.064)
Edu	-0.025 (0.016)	-0.020 (0.016)	-0.014 (0.016)	-0.035** (0.016)	-0.001 (0.016)	0.084*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,205	1,206	1,204	1,207	1,200	1,208
R ²	0.116	0.115	0.132	0.118	0.103	0.149
Adjusted R ²	0.022	0.021	0.040	0.024	0.007	0.058

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A24: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust (High SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.022 (0.038)	-0.040 (0.038)	0.050 (0.038)	-0.044 (0.039)	-0.038 (0.039)	-0.015 (0.037)
Gender: Female	-0.191*** (0.058)	-0.161*** (0.058)	-0.128** (0.058)	-0.082 (0.058)	-0.274*** (0.060)	-0.167*** (0.056)
Edu	-0.036* (0.019)	-0.059*** (0.019)	-0.016 (0.019)	-0.048** (0.019)	-0.068*** (0.020)	0.032* (0.019)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,197	1,196	1,197	1,198	1,191	1,199
R ²	0.165	0.160	0.138	0.135	0.159	0.120
Adjusted R ²	0.073	0.068	0.044	0.040	0.066	0.024

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A25: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust (Low SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.048 (0.046)	-0.080* (0.046)	-0.080* (0.046)	-0.117** (0.046)	-0.084* (0.045)	-0.041 (0.047)
Gender: Female	-0.045 (0.063)	-0.089 (0.063)	0.042 (0.063)	-0.041 (0.062)	-0.164*** (0.062)	-0.181*** (0.064)
Edu	-0.025 (0.016)	-0.019 (0.016)	-0.015 (0.016)	-0.035** (0.016)	0.0002 (0.016)	0.083*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,205	1,206	1,204	1,207	1,200	1,208
R ²	0.117	0.118	0.131	0.122	0.105	0.148
Adjusted R ²	0.022	0.024	0.038	0.029	0.010	0.058

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A26: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust (High SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	0.020 (0.049)	-0.007 (0.049)	0.060 (0.049)	-0.050 (0.050)	-0.073 (0.051)	-0.006 (0.047)
Gender: Female	-0.190*** (0.058)	-0.162*** (0.058)	-0.123** (0.058)	-0.086 (0.059)	-0.280*** (0.060)	-0.168*** (0.056)
Edu	-0.036* (0.019)	-0.059*** (0.019)	-0.016 (0.019)	-0.048** (0.019)	-0.067*** (0.020)	0.032* (0.019)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,197	1,196	1,197	1,198	1,191	1,199
R ²	0.164	0.159	0.138	0.134	0.160	0.120
Adjusted R ²	0.073	0.067	0.044	0.040	0.067	0.023

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A27: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust (Low SES Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.108** (0.055)	-0.049 (0.055)	-0.083 (0.055)	-0.084 (0.055)	-0.065 (0.054)	-0.084 (0.056)
Gender: Female	-0.050 (0.063)	-0.086 (0.063)	0.042 (0.063)	-0.038 (0.063)	-0.162*** (0.062)	-0.184*** (0.064)
Edu	-0.024 (0.016)	-0.019 (0.016)	-0.014 (0.016)	-0.035* (0.016)	0.0002 (0.016)	0.084*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,205	1,206	1,204	1,207	1,200	1,208
R ²	0.119	0.116	0.130	0.119	0.104	0.149
Adjusted R ²	0.025	0.022	0.037	0.025	0.008	0.059

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A28: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (High Edu Respondents)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	0.024 (0.095)	-0.041 (0.097)	0.095 (0.098)	-0.044 (0.099)	-0.026 (0.105)	-0.040 (0.087)
Gender: Female	-0.159** (0.078)	-0.089 (0.080)	-0.177** (0.081)	-0.096 (0.081)	-0.192** (0.086)	-0.088 (0.071)
SES	-0.025 (0.132)	0.021 (0.135)	-0.060 (0.136)	-0.149 (0.137)	-0.096 (0.146)	0.048 (0.121)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	652	654	651	652	651	653
R ²	0.182	0.217	0.180	0.178	0.184	0.207
Adjusted R ²	0.011	0.055	0.010	0.007	0.015	0.043

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A29: Exposure to Homicide and Trust (Low Edu Respondents)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.033 (0.044)	-0.027 (0.044)	-0.059 (0.044)	-0.061 (0.043)	0.012 (0.043)	-0.073 (0.045)
Gender: Female	-0.079 (0.051)	-0.108** (0.050)	0.041 (0.050)	-0.029 (0.050)	-0.201*** (0.049)	-0.198*** (0.052)
SES	-0.057*** (0.017)	-0.040** (0.017)	-0.030* (0.017)	-0.049*** (0.017)	-0.013 (0.016)	0.066*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,750	1,748	1,750	1,753	1,740	1,754
R ²	0.100	0.095	0.109	0.101	0.098	0.103
Adjusted R ²	0.035	0.029	0.044	0.036	0.032	0.037

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A30: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust (High Edu Respondents)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	0.026 (0.060)	0.017 (0.061)	0.092 (0.062)	0.079 (0.062)	-0.048 (0.066)	-0.022 (0.055)
Gender: Female	-0.159** (0.078)	-0.090 (0.080)	-0.178** (0.080)	-0.100 (0.081)	-0.192** (0.086)	-0.089 (0.071)
SES	-0.027 (0.132)	0.018 (0.135)	-0.066 (0.136)	-0.158 (0.137)	-0.092 (0.146)	0.049 (0.121)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	652	654	651	652	651	653
R ²	0.182	0.217	0.182	0.180	0.185	0.207
Adjusted R ²	0.012	0.055	0.012	0.009	0.016	0.043

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A31: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust (Low Edu Respondents)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.057 (0.037)	-0.093** (0.037)	-0.041 (0.036)	-0.116*** (0.037)	-0.064* (0.036)	-0.018 (0.038)
Gender: Female	-0.081 (0.051)	-0.113** (0.050)	0.043 (0.050)	-0.033 (0.050)	-0.206*** (0.049)	-0.194*** (0.052)
SES	-0.057*** (0.017)	-0.039** (0.017)	-0.031* (0.017)	-0.048*** (0.016)	-0.012 (0.016)	0.065*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,750	1,748	1,750	1,753	1,740	1,754
R ²	0.101	0.098	0.109	0.106	0.100	0.101

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A32: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust (High Edu Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.024 (0.100)	-0.119 (0.102)	-0.078 (0.103)	-0.036 (0.104)	-0.140 (0.111)	-0.067 (0.092)
Gender: Female	-0.159** (0.078)	-0.095 (0.080)	-0.177** (0.081)	-0.099 (0.081)	-0.198** (0.086)	-0.092 (0.071)
SES	-0.024 (0.132)	0.020 (0.135)	-0.056 (0.136)	-0.150 (0.137)	-0.095 (0.146)	0.047 (0.121)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	652	654	651	652	651	653
R ²	0.182	0.219	0.180	0.177	0.187	0.208

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A33: Exposure to Military Operations and Trust (Low Edu Respondents)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't (1)	Federal Gov't (2)	Subnat'l Police (3)	Federal Police (4)	Military (5)	Community (6)
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.039 (0.043)	-0.009 (0.042)	0.003 (0.042)	-0.055 (0.042)	-0.047 (0.041)	-0.011 (0.043)
Gender: Female	-0.080 (0.051)	-0.107** (0.051)	0.046 (0.050)	-0.030 (0.050)	-0.207*** (0.049)	-0.193*** (0.052)
SES	-0.057*** (0.017)	-0.041** (0.017)	-0.031* (0.017)	-0.049*** (0.017)	-0.013 (0.016)	0.065*** (0.017)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,750	1,748	1,750	1,753	1,740	1,754
R ²	0.101	0.095	0.108	0.101	0.099	0.101
Adjusted R ²	0.035	0.028	0.043	0.036	0.033	0.036

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

10 Movers & Trust

In our main results, we remove all individuals who do not live in the same municipality as where they grew up, as we cannot reliably determine their levels of exposure to our variables of interest. However, having the ability to move municipalities is often a function of one's socioeconomic status and could perhaps be endogenous to long-term trust. Here, we examine if whether or not a respondent moved municipalities from where they were born is associated with trust in all institutions and the community. We control for SES, education, and gender as we do in our main analysis. We find no statistically significant relationship. For this analysis we utilize non-standardized trust variables, as standardization occurs in our analysis following the dropping of "movers."

11 Risk-Set Matching

Here, we provide an alternative analysis for our evaluation of continuous exposure to violence, confrontations, and operations based on the principles of risk set matching (Rosenbaum, 2020). Via this approach, we restrict comparisons to respondents in municipalities that were on the path of exposure to each of our three variables of interest, but vary in the timing of the onset of exposure. To do so, we define the initial year of exposure for each municipality as follows for each of our three variables of interest:

1. Homicide: A homicide spike, or the first year a municipality's homicide rate exceeded the mean plus 1/2 of a standard deviation

Table A34: Respondents who Moved Municipalities and Trust

	Dependent variable:					
	Moved Municipalities					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Trust: Fed Gov	0.001 (0.004)					
Trust: Subnat Gov		-0.001 (0.005)				
Trust: Military			0.002 (0.005)			
Trust: Federal Police				0.0002 (0.004)		
Trust: Subnat Police					-0.004 (0.005)	
Trust: Community						-0.005 (0.004)
SES	-0.044*** (0.014)	-0.042*** (0.014)	-0.045*** (0.014)	-0.043*** (0.014)	-0.044*** (0.014)	-0.044*** (0.014)
Edu	-0.006 (0.004)	-0.006 (0.004)	-0.006 (0.004)	-0.005 (0.004)	-0.006 (0.004)	-0.005 (0.004)
Gender: Male	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.004 (0.014)	-0.005 (0.014)	-0.006 (0.014)	-0.005 (0.014)	-0.003 (0.014)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,855	2,850	2,836	2,856	2,852	2,855
R ²	0.099	0.098	0.099	0.098	0.100	0.099
Adjusted R ²	0.059	0.059	0.059	0.059	0.061	0.059

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

2. Confrontations: The first year a municipality experienced extended exposure to confrontations, that is two or more consecutive years of exposure
3. Operations: The first year a municipality experienced extended exposure to operations, that is two or more consecutive years of exposure

Based on these definitions, we then define two groups of individuals for each analysis: 1) an early exposed group (those exposed to this initial municipal-level “treatment” during their first ten years of life), and 2) a not-yet-exposed group (those residing within a municipality that is exposed to one of these “treatments,” but after their first ten years of life). For each analysis, we restrict our sample to only analyze these two groups (early exposed and not-yet exposed). We combine these to create a risk-set sample, and conduct within-cohort analyses (an analysis restricted to individuals born in the same year) to measure the exposure to violence, confrontations, and operations within the first ten years of life. Because some of our cohorts were never exposed to military operations or confrontations during their first ten years of life (e.g., those in 1992 were not exposed to confrontations), these cohorts are dropped from our analysis as their is no variation in this treatment variable. We then conduct a meta analysis to estimate the pooled effect across all cohorts using the *metagen* package, utilizing the common effects model estimate.

In all models, we incorporate all controls used in our standard estimations, but we do not include fixed effects for birth year or municipality. Birth year fixed effects are unnecessary, as separate models are estimated for each birth year cohort. Municipality fixed effects are dropped due to few observations per municipality.

12 Disentangling Effects of Confrontations vs. Operations

In this section, we disentangle the effects of exposure to military confrontations conditional on exposure to military operations (deployment). That is to say, we consider the effect of exposure to confrontations within municipalities that were all targeted for militarization by the state government. We do this by replicating both our continuous evaluation and quasi-experimental evaluation of exposure to confrontations on trust, but only for those who experienced operations. In essence, this analysis isolates the *additional* impact of confrontations, holding constant individuals’ baseline experience of deployment.

Table A35: Risk-Set Matching Meta-Analysis Coefficients

Violence Exposure			Confrontations Exposure			Operations Exposure		
IV	Coef.	P-value	IV	Coef.	P-value	IV	Coef.	P-value
Subnat'l Gov't	-0.106	0.081	Subnat'l Gov't	0.020	0.471	Subnat'l Gov't	0.004	0.894
Fed Gov't	-0.149	0.013	Fed Gov't	-0.028	0.300	Fed Gov't	-0.016	0.583
Subnat'l Police	-0.021	0.736	Subnat'l Police	0.030	0.280	Subnat'l Police	-0.005	0.877
Fed Police	-0.067	0.251	Fed Police	-0.067	0.014	Fed Police	-0.053	0.078
Military	-0.193	0.001	Military	-0.038	0.136	Military	-0.044	0.132
Community	-0.192	0.001	Community	-0.019	0.507	Community	0.012	0.712

In this case of our continuous evaluation, we subset our data to include only those who were exposed to military deployments (operations or confrontations) during their first ten years of life ($n = 1,005$). Among these, 731 were exposed to some level of confrontations between the military and organized criminal groups. To disentangle the difference between experience military deployments without confrontations and those without, we examine how exposure to confrontations during 0-10 years of life affects trust later in life among this subset of respondents. For the quasi-experimental analysis, we subset our data to include only those who were exposed to military deployments (operations or confrontations) from 2007-2011, but at any age ($n = 1,633$). Among these, 1,254 were also exposed to some form of military confrontations during this period. Recalling that this strategy compares those who were exposed vs. not exposed among an eligible vs. ineligible cohort (based on birth year), we then once again interact their eligibility for exposure with the mean number of confrontations in their municipality from 2007-2011. Due to smaller sample size, we are inconsistently able to estimate robust standard errors; we present conventional standard errors for these models.

Results are presented in Tables A36 and A37. With respect to the continuous evaluation, we find negative coefficients with respect to trust in the federal government, federal police, and military, but they do not reach statistical significance. But, in the case of our quasi-experimental design, we find negative and statistically significant results in the cases of trust in the federal police and military. This analysis provides supporting evidence for the fact that violent confrontations have an additional impact on trust. In other words, even conditional on experiencing a military deployment, the experience of exposure to violent confrontations has an independent effect on decreasing trust.

Table A36: Exposure to Military Confrontations and Trust among Respondents Exposed to Operations (0-10yrs)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Neighbors
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.006 (0.041)	-0.036 (0.040)	0.015 (0.041)	-0.051 (0.039)	-0.020 (0.040)	-0.020 (0.042)
Gender: Female	-0.131** (0.065)	-0.091 (0.063)	-0.048 (0.065)	-0.099 (0.062)	-0.237*** (0.064)	-0.092 (0.066)
SES	-0.045 (0.069)	-0.045 (0.067)	-0.042 (0.069)	-0.136** (0.066)	-0.084 (0.068)	0.218*** (0.070)
Edu	-0.043** (0.022)	-0.019 (0.021)	-0.013 (0.022)	-0.025 (0.021)	-0.004 (0.021)	0.023 (0.022)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	995	992	995	996	988	998
R ²	0.119	0.133	0.133	0.136	0.103	0.118
Adjusted R ²	0.029	0.044	0.044	0.048	0.010	0.029

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A37: Military Confrontations and Cohort Eligibility for Exposure among Respondents Exposed to Operations (2007-2011)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.013 (0.017)	-0.025 (0.017)	-0.002 (0.016)	-0.038** (0.016)	-0.027* (0.016)	-0.005 (0.017)
Cohort: Eligible	-0.030 (0.104)	0.044 (0.103)	0.083 (0.104)	0.195* (0.100)	0.104 (0.101)	0.037 (0.105)
Gender: Female	-0.106** (0.052)	-0.118** (0.052)	-0.037 (0.052)	-0.051 (0.050)	-0.218*** (0.050)	-0.143*** (0.052)
SES	-0.103* (0.054)	-0.063 (0.054)	-0.069 (0.054)	-0.109** (0.052)	-0.097* (0.053)	0.049 (0.055)
Edu	-0.033** (0.015)	-0.034** (0.015)	-0.018 (0.015)	-0.024 (0.015)	-0.003 (0.015)	0.070*** (0.015)
Age	-0.036*** (0.012)	-0.014 (0.012)	-0.026** (0.012)	0.003 (0.011)	-0.004 (0.012)	0.011 (0.012)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,614	1,614	1,614	1,616	1,606	1,618
R ²	0.083	0.090	0.081	0.092	0.074	0.095
Adjusted R ²	0.038	0.045	0.036	0.047	0.028	0.051

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

13 Partisan Effects Results

Table A38: Exposure to Violence/Militarization and Vote for PAN/PRI or Abstention/Null Vote

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	PAN/PRI			Abstention/Null		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	0.003 (0.021)			0.026 (0.028)		
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)		-0.027* (0.014)			0.043** (0.019)	
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)			-0.053*** (0.020)			0.053* (0.028)
Gender: Female	0.043** (0.019)	0.042** (0.019)	0.041** (0.019)	-0.042* (0.025)	-0.041 (0.025)	-0.041 (0.025)
SES	0.030 (0.020)	0.030 (0.020)	0.030 (0.020)	-0.097*** (0.027)	-0.097*** (0.027)	-0.097*** (0.027)
Edu	0.013** (0.005)	0.013** (0.005)	0.013** (0.005)	-0.021*** (0.007)	-0.021*** (0.007)	-0.021*** (0.007)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636
R ²	0.118	0.120	0.122	0.127	0.129	0.128
Adjusted R ²	0.049	0.051	0.053	0.059	0.061	0.060

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A39: Exposure to Violence/Militarization and Vote for MORENA

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	-0.004 (0.020)	-0.004 (0.020)				
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)		0.006 (0.008)		0.006 (0.008)		0.006 (0.008)
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)			-0.008 (0.012)	-0.008 (0.012)		
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)					0.003 (0.020)	0.003 (0.020)
Gender: Female	-0.023 (0.020)	-0.023 (0.020)	-0.023 (0.020)	-0.023 (0.020)	-0.023 (0.020)	-0.023 (0.020)
SES	0.018 (0.020)	0.018 (0.020)	0.018 (0.020)	0.018 (0.020)	0.018 (0.020)	0.018 (0.020)
Edu	0.007 (0.005)	0.007 (0.005)	0.007 (0.005)	0.007 (0.005)	0.007 (0.005)	0.007 (0.005)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636
R ²	0.119	0.119	0.119	0.119	0.119	0.119
Adjusted R ²	0.050	0.050	0.050	0.050	0.050	0.050

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A40: Exposure to Violence/Militarization and Vote for PAN/PRI or Abstention/Null Vote (Controlling for Current Homicide Rate)

	Dependent variable:					
	PAN/PRI			Abstention/Null		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Homicide Exposure (0-10yrs)	0.003 (0.019)			0.026 (0.026)		
Mil Confrontations Exposure (0-10yrs)		-0.027** (0.013)			0.043** (0.018)	
Mil Operations Exposure (0-10yrs)			-0.053** (0.022)			0.053* (0.028)
Current Homicide Rate (per 100k)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.002 (0.001)	-0.002 (0.002)	-0.010 (0.009)	-0.010 (0.009)	-0.010 (0.010)
Gender: Female	0.043** (0.019)	0.042** (0.019)	0.041** (0.019)	-0.042 (0.026)	-0.041 (0.026)	-0.041 (0.026)
SES	0.030 (0.020)	0.030 (0.020)	0.030 (0.020)	-0.097*** (0.027)	-0.097*** (0.027)	-0.097*** (0.027)
Edu	0.013** (0.006)	0.013** (0.005)	0.013** (0.005)	-0.021*** (0.008)	-0.021*** (0.008)	-0.021*** (0.008)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Birth Year FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636	1,636
R ²	0.118	0.120	0.122	0.127	0.129	0.128
Adjusted R ²	0.049	0.051	0.053	0.059	0.061	0.060

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

14 Quasi-Experimental Design: Balance & Pre-Trends

Here we provide evidence supporting the validity of our quasi-experimental design. Figure A6 supports a lack of notable pre-trends in military activity (as measured by drug-trafficking related detentions by SEDENA) among municipalities where there were military vs. OCG confrontations in 2007 (the launch of the Drug War). Trends in detentions were relatively constant across these two groups of municipalities.

Further, Table A18 demonstrates balance in potential confounding variables among individuals classified as "eligible" vs. "ineligible" for treatment.

Figure A6: Pre-Drug War Detentions

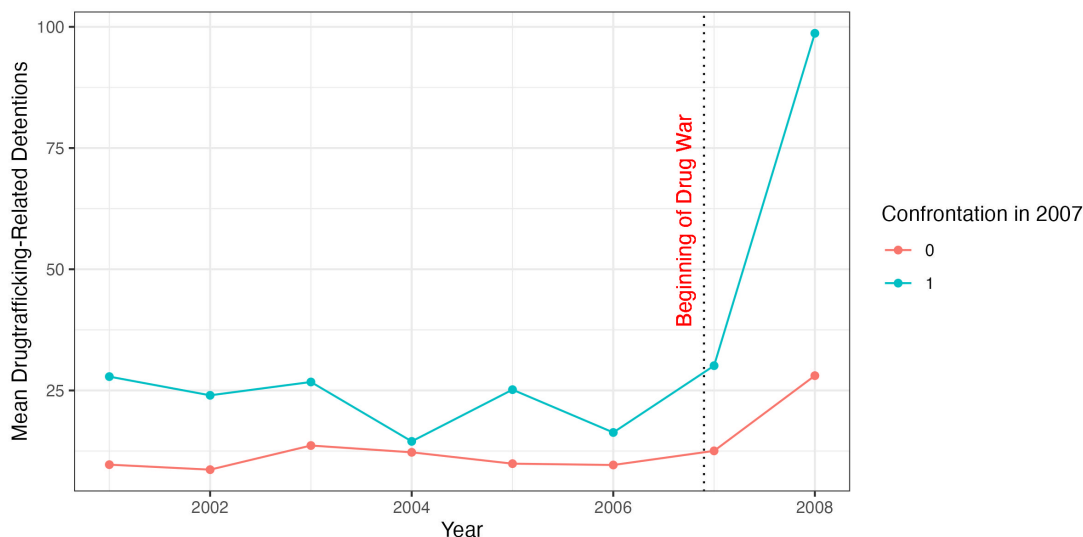


Table A41: Mean Variable Values by Cohort Subset and SD of Variables

	Cohort: Eligible	Cohort: Ineligible	SD
Homicide Rate (Time of Survey)	22.15	23.40	23.59
Pre-Drug War Detentions	12.15	14.08	19.97
SES	2.00	1.93	0.54
Gender: Female	0.48	0.58	0.50

15 Quasi-Experimental Results with Expansion of Exposure Cohort

In these models, we consider a less conservative definition of the cohort eligible for treatment. We expand the cohort from those only born between 2001 and 2005, to instead be those born between 1999 and 2005. Such a definition is less conservative, as it includes respondents who were 12 or 11 years of age in the years 2010 and 2011. However, it also expands to include certain respondents who were between the ages of 7 and 10 in the years 2007-2010 who were previously excluded in the main analysis.

The coefficient of interest (the interaction between average military confrontations/operations and whether or not a respondent was eligible to be exposed as defined by their cohort) is largely consistent with main results across the models. All coefficients are negative, while the significance varies to some degree. Some variation is expected, as the definition of the cohort is less restrictive in this case.

Table A42: Confrontations X Cohort Eligibility (Expanded)

	Dependent variable:					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible (Expanded) X Mean Conf. (2007-11)	-0.023 (0.016)	-0.017 (0.016)	-0.025 (0.018)	-0.030* (0.017)	-0.037** (0.015)	-0.010 (0.016)
Cohort: Eligible (Expanded)	0.076 (0.092)	0.085 (0.093)	0.058 (0.093)	0.053 (0.095)	0.047 (0.094)	0.140 (0.091)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.108** (0.043)	-0.033 (0.043)	-0.045 (0.042)	-0.208*** (0.042)	-0.173*** (0.042)
SES	-0.120** (0.048)	-0.051 (0.048)	-0.064 (0.047)	-0.093* (0.048)	-0.114** (0.048)	0.050 (0.049)
Edu	-0.026** (0.013)	-0.033** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	-0.037*** (0.013)	-0.014 (0.013)	0.061*** (0.013)
Age	-0.033*** (0.011)	-0.010 (0.011)	-0.034*** (0.011)	-0.012 (0.011)	-0.016 (0.011)	0.017 (0.011)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.084	0.083	0.083	0.081	0.091
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.041	0.039	0.040	0.037	0.048

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

Table A43: Operations X Cohort Eligibility (Expanded)

	<i>Dependent variable:</i>					
	Subnat'l Gov't	Federal Gov't	Subnat'l Police	Federal Police	Military	Community
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Cohort: Eligible (Expanded) X Mean Ops. (2007-11)	-0.133 (0.115)	-0.017 (0.111)	-0.048 (0.114)	-0.212* (0.112)	-0.200* (0.111)	-0.076 (0.111)
Cohort: Eligible (Expanded)	0.090 (0.099)	0.066 (0.099)	0.039 (0.100)	0.086 (0.101)	0.067 (0.101)	0.154 (0.098)
Gender: Female	-0.113*** (0.043)	-0.107** (0.043)	-0.032 (0.043)	-0.046 (0.042)	-0.208*** (0.042)	-0.174*** (0.042)
SES	-0.119** (0.048)	-0.050 (0.048)	-0.063 (0.047)	-0.091* (0.048)	-0.112** (0.048)	0.051 (0.049)
Edu	-0.027** (0.013)	-0.034** (0.013)	-0.016 (0.013)	-0.038*** (0.013)	-0.015 (0.013)	0.061*** (0.013)
Age	-0.033*** (0.011)	-0.010 (0.011)	-0.035*** (0.011)	-0.012 (0.011)	-0.016 (0.011)	0.017 (0.011)
Mun FE	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Robust SEs	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Observations	2,402	2,402	2,401	2,405	2,391	2,407
R ²	0.087	0.084	0.082	0.083	0.080	0.091
Adjusted R ²	0.044	0.040	0.038	0.040	0.036	0.048

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

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